



Advancing
Art&Design

The Poetic Structure of a Twelfth-Century Chinese Pictorial Dream Journey

Author(s): Valérie Malenfer Ortiz

Source: *The Art Bulletin*, Jun., 1994, Vol. 76, No. 2 (Jun., 1994), pp. 257-278

Published by: CAA

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3046022>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



JSTOR

CAA is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *The Art Bulletin*

The Poetic Structure of a Twelfth-Century Chinese Pictorial Dream Journey

Valérie Malenfer Ortiz

In memory of Odette Sterekx (1905–1993)

The painters whom the invading Jurchens pushed to the Yangzi River Valley by the twelfth century were fascinated by the southern vistas of lakes and misty hills. They found there the visual inspiration not only to depict a tangible atmospheric space receding to infinity but also to suggest emotions and dreams through the veiling and unveiling of the landscape. In addition to vaunting their technical mastery of pictorial space, painters viewed their work not merely as a craft, but as an intellectual endeavor not unlike poetry.¹ It is in the Southern Song (1127–1279) that landscape painters began to borrow from the structure of poems in order to enrich painting with a lyrical quality. As painters took inspiration from poetry, poets, such as Lu You (1125–1209) and Yang Wanli (1127–1206), viewed the natural world as if it were brushed in ink on paper or silk, and they filled their poems with precise visual images. For instance, Lu You noted in his *Diary* on the twenty-second day of the seventh month of 1170, “Wind and sun clear and beautiful, with waves flat as a mat, white clouds and green peaks, bright bands into the distance. All day was like traveling through a painting. Truly forgotten were the toils of travel.”² The poet has described his own response to the images that pass before his eyes. This vision of nature, modified by selection, focus, concealment, and shifting views, encouraged in painters a predilection not only for the keen observation of things and their spatial articulation, but also for the experience of viewing. As will be seen, the convergence of technical means and poetic ideals contributed to the creation of what may be called “poetic space,” the most significant thematic component of Southern Song landscape painting.³ The image thus generated did not merely illustrate a poem; its spatial structure was, like that of a poem, a vehicle for carrying the imagination beyond the boundaries of its own particular form into the realm of dream; it beguiled the viewer’s perception as it reconciled the real and the illusory, and, in the end, it achieved a perfect balance between visual reality

and lyrical suggestion in the representation of the outside world.

One of the accepted masterpieces that reflects the poetic vision of Southern Song landscape painters is a handscroll dated 1170, preserved in the Tokyo National Museum, and titled *Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang woyou tu*) (Figs. 1–6). Because it is dated and of high technical and artistic quality, it occupies a central position in the history of Chinese painting.⁴ Its author, a certain Li, is unknown, although he may be a relative of Li Gonglin (ca. 1049–1106). He came from Shucheng in modern Anhui Province, in the lower Yangzi region, also known as Jiangnan. As indicated in the colophons written after the painting in 1170–71, *Dream Journey* offers an accurate vision of the area of lakes and marshes that unite the well-known Xiao and Xiang rivers. The region had considerable appeal not only for its luxuriant beauty, famous for its waterland of clouds and mist, but also for its literary and artistic importance, because some of China’s most celebrated poets, painters, and critics had sought seclusion there since antiquity. Paintings and poems on the Xiao Xiang have always been admired both as vehicles for imaginary journeys and as reminders of the rich artistic tradition of the South. The late Northern Song scholar Mi Fu (1052–1107) and his family contributed to the creation of the Jiangnan, or Southern, tradition of painting as an independent artistic movement and especially praised the depictions of the Xiao Xiang.⁵ From the Southern Song onwards, once the elite of China found itself confined to the Yangzi area, the Xiao Xiang became a renewed place of mental and political escape. After he had come to the Jin as a Song legate, for example, Mi Fu’s son-in-law, Wu Li (d. 1142), was put under arrest and became Edict Attendant in the Jin Hanlin Academy. In a seven-characters quatrain, titled “On a Painting of the Xiao Xiang,” he contrasts his former life under the Song and his present circumstances under the Jin.

On springtime water of the Southland, greener than
wine,

¹ For his keen observations and his shrewd and generous advice regarding this paper and its preliminary work, I am most grateful to Richard Edwards. His work on Southern Song painting was my earliest and most inspiring guide. He wrote on the Song painters’ attention to the visually true in “Painting and Poetry in the Late Sung,” in *Words and Images*, 405–430. Concerning the objectivity in Song painting, see *idem*, “Wu in Late Sung Landscape,” in *Proceedings of the International Conference on Sinology: History of Art Section*, Taipei, 1980, 37–72. I am also particularly grateful to Richard Barnhart, Jonathan Hay, Elizabeth Horton Sharf, David Sensabaugh, and A. Richard Turner.

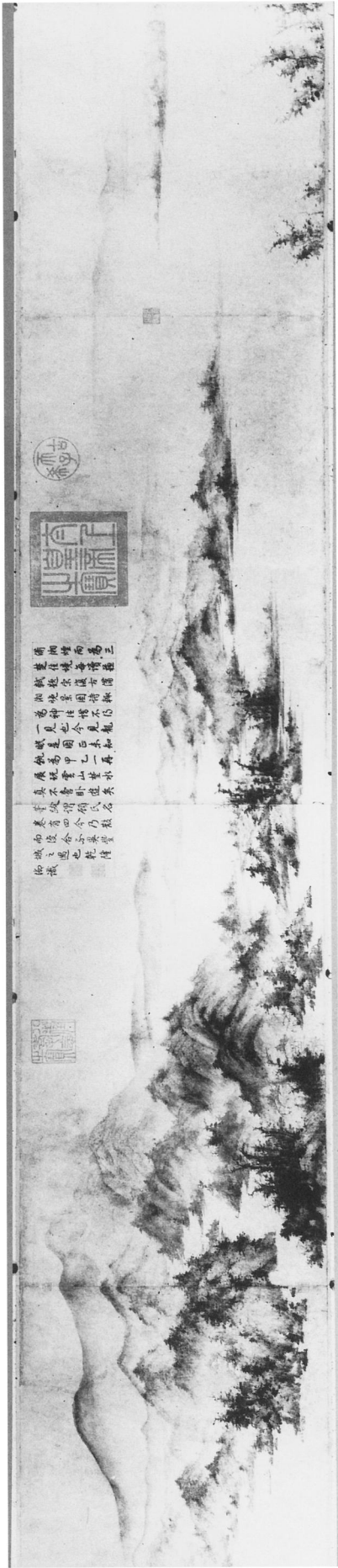
² Lu You, *Ru Shu ji* (*Diary of a Trip to Sichuan*) in *Siku chuanshu* (1776), repr., Taipei: Shangwu, 1980, DCXL, fol. 5. *South China in the Twelfth Century*, trans. J. Smythe and C. S. Chang, Hongkong, 1981, 90–91.

³ John Hay has used this expression in connection with the paintings and inscriptions on paintings by Qian Xuan (ca. 1235–after 1301) in

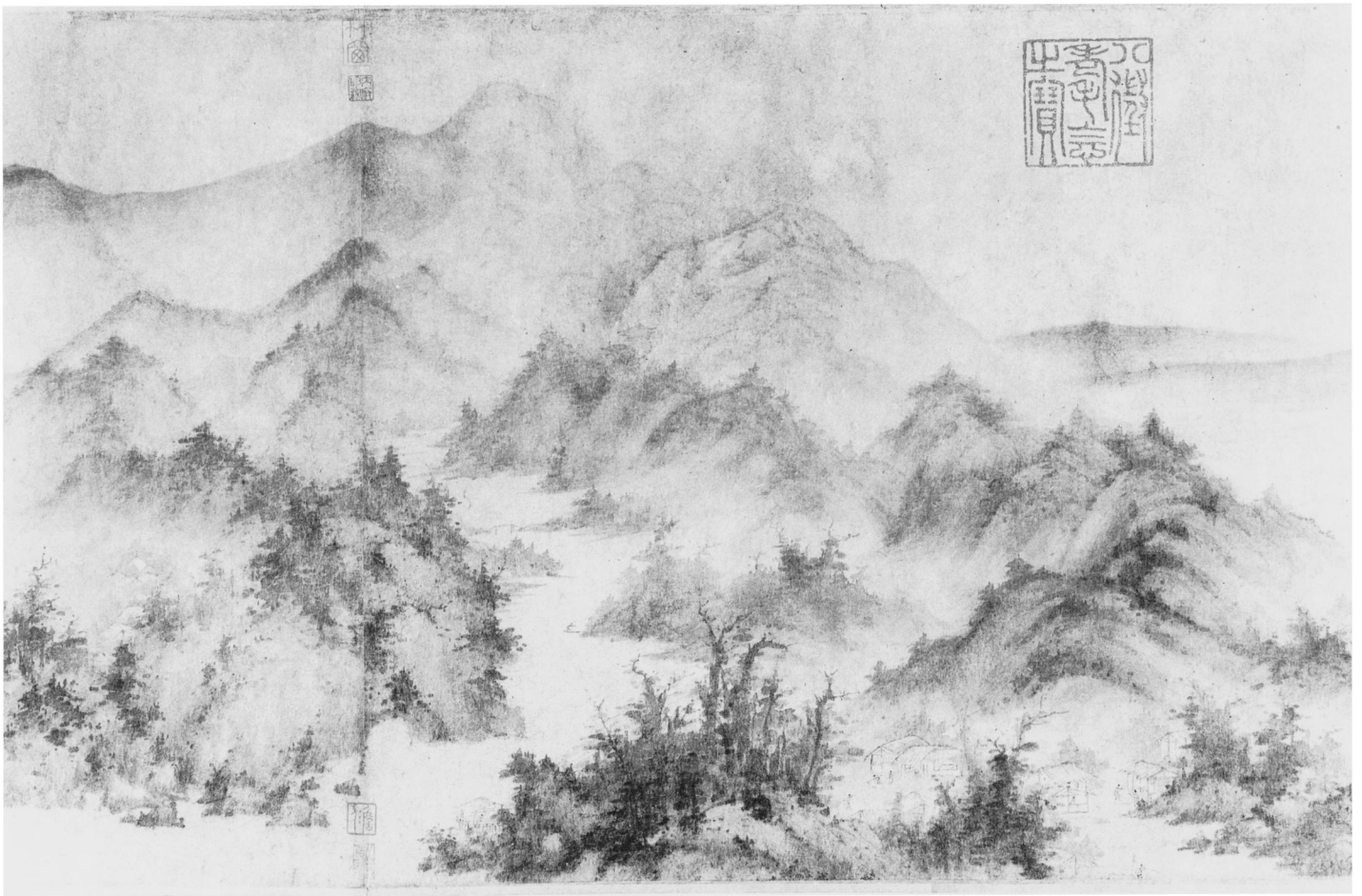
which he addressed the question of space and poetry from a theoretical point of view. See “Poetic Space: Ch’ien Hsüan and the Association of Painting and Poetry,” in *Words and Images*, 173–198.

⁴ See V. Malenfer, “*Dream Journey over the Xiao and Xiang*: Scholar-Amateur Landscape Painting in Southern Song China,” Ph.D. diss., Harvard University, 1990. The style of the painting has been the subject of a study by K. Suzuki in “Shōshō gayu zukan ni tsuite,” *Tōkyō daigaku tōyō bunka kenkyū-jō kiyō*, LXI, 1973, 1–63, and LXXIX, 1979, 1–84.

⁵ Mi Fu traveled many times along the Yangzi River and lived in Changsha, located at the confluence of the Xiao and the Xiang, between 1075 and 1081, before his move to Hangzhou. See *Songren zhuanji ziliao soym*, comp. Chang Bide *et al.*, Taipei: Dingwen Shuju, 1974–76, 541.



1 Anonymous, *Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang woyou tu*), handscroll, ink on paper. Tokyo, National Museum (photo: Asian Art Photographic Distribution, University of Michigan)

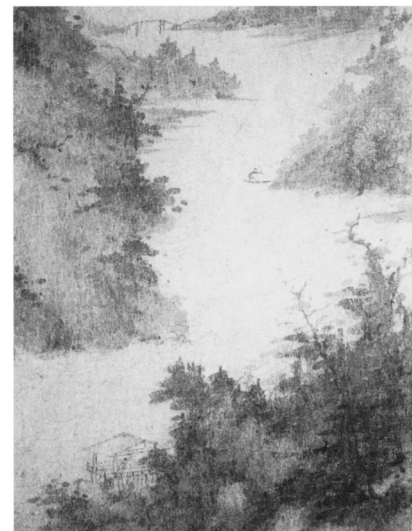


2 Anonymous, *Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang woyou tu*), central section, handscroll, ink on paper. Tokyo, National Museum (photo: Tôyô bunka kenkyû-jô, Tokyo University)

Wanderers ply back and forth, boats for their home.
Suddenly seeing this painting, it seems but a dream,
For now, on saddled horse I age in windswept sands.⁶

Wu Li dreams about his homeland in the South where he feels suddenly transported as he views a painting of the Xiao Xiang. The poetic flavor of the Xiao Xiang was what painters sought to capture in order to transport the mind of the viewer to the coveted place. For instance, Mi Fu's son, the early Southern Song painter Mi Youren (ca. 1072–1151), explained, "all my life I have known the exceptional sights of the Xiao Xiang region. Each time I climbed and reached the beautiful spots I always sketched their true flavor (*qu*), making a long scroll to delight the eyes."⁷ A first-hand experience of the landscape enabled Mi to fill his painting with the poetic flavor suitable to lead the imagination of an educated viewer into the mythical region.

Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang also illustrates the more specific poetic theme of the *Eight Views of the Xiao and*



3 Anonymous, *Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang woyou tu*), detail of pavilion, central section, handscroll, ink on paper. Tokyo, National Museum (photo: Malenfer Ortiz)

⁶ Quoted in K. Yoshikawa, *Five Hundred Years of Chinese Poetry, 1150–1650: The Chin, Yuan, and Ming Dynasties*, trans. J. T. Wixted, Princeton, 1989, 23.

⁷ Quoted in ZGHLLB, 684.

Xiang. The *Eight Views* were invented at the end of the Northern Song, around 1060, by Song Di (ca. 1015–80), who first painted them on the walls of a terrace overlooking Changsha where he was serving as vice director of



4 Anonymous, *Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang woyou tu*), final section, handscroll, ink on paper. Tokyo, National Museum (photo: Tōyō bunka kenkyū-jō, Tokyo University)

administration.⁸ His depiction was primarily a translation of his visual experience of the atmospheric impressions characteristic of the site, yet it also had deeply evocative qualities.⁹ Song succeeded in capturing the mood typical of certain seasons or certain times of the day through very simple and earthy images of nature, such as a fishing village, a bell, the autumn moon, etc. The painter originally invented this grouping of different scenes, for which the scholar-critic

⁸ Concerning the sources for Song Di's biography and for a discussion of the origins of the Xiao Xiang theme, see Chen Gaohua, 320–329; S. Shimada, "Sōto to shōshō hakkei," *Nanga Kanshō*, x, 4, 1941, 6–13; A. Watanabe, *Shōshō hakkei zu*, in *Nihon no bijutsu*, CXXIV, Tokyo, 1976, 18; R. Stanley-Baker, "Mid-Muromachi Paintings of the Eight Views of the Hsiao and Hsiang," Ph.D. diss., Princeton University, 1979, 1–5; A. Murck, "Eight Views of the Hsiao and Hsiang by Wang Hung," in *Images of the Mind: Selections from the Edward L. Elliot Family and John B. Elliot Collection of Chinese Calligraphy and Painting*, Princeton, 1984, 214; R. M. Barnhart, "Shining Rivers: Eight Views of the Hsiao and Hsiang in Sung Painting," *Proceedings of the International Colloquium on Chinese Art History* (1991), Taipei, The National Palace Museum, 1992, 1, 45–95.

⁹ According to both the author of *Xuanhe huapu* and Guo Ruoxu (ca. 1080), the popularity of Song's paintings was encouraged by their poetic quality. *Xuanhe huapu*, pref., supposedly by Song Emperor Huizong (r. 1101–26), in *HSCS*, xii, 1, 129–130; Guo Ruoxu, *Tuhua jianwen zhi*, 3: 5–6, trans. A. Soper, *Kuo Jo-hsü's "Experiences in Painting"*, Washington, D.C., 1951, 45. Mi Fu also mentioned that Song Di achieved a peace in form and an elegance of mood that he learned from Li Cheng (919–967), who understood the subtleties of poetry. *Huashi* in *MSCS*, 9: 24. On Li Cheng's possible depiction of the Eight Views, see Shimada (as in n. 8), 6.

Shen Gua (1031–95) wrote eight poetic titles.¹⁰ The lyrical richness of the combination of a set of paintings with a set of poems gave the theme a long-lasting fame in all the artistic circles of the Southern Song, when it began to be called the *Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang bajing*) and when it stood as a symbol for the poetic ideal inherited from Song Di.

The theme of the *Eight Views* developed in conjunction with the ideal of representing space in a visually accurate manner; both contributed to the emergence of poetic painting. The idea that a painting should trigger the imagination of the viewer beyond the depicted forms was discussed primarily by Song Di's friend, the great poet and aesthetic critic Su Shi (1036–1101), who remains one of the most important theorists of "picture idea" (*huayi*) or poetic painting.¹¹ In formulating the notion that "painting and poetry

¹⁰ The eight titles given by Shen are as follows: "Wild Geese Descending to Sandbar" (*Pingsha yanle*); "Returning Sails off Distant Shores" (*Yuanpu fangui*); "Mountain Market in Clearing Mist" (*Shanshi pinglan*); "River and Sky in Evening Snow" (*Jiangtian muxue*); "Autumn Moon over Lake Dongting" (*Dongting qiuyue*); "Night Rain on the Xiao and Xiang" (*Xiaoxiang yeyu*); "Evening Bell from Mist-Shrouded Temple" (*Yansi wanzhong*); "Fishing Village in Twilight Glow" (*Yucun lezhao*). *Mengqi bitan*, ed. Hu Taojing (with annotations), Beijing: Zhonghua, 1959, 17: 9–10.

¹¹ Su's famous lines on the futility of discussing painting on the basis of external form (*xingsi*) read:

To discuss painting in terms of formal resemblance is childish;
To compose poems that must be a particular poem is to misunderstand poetry completely;



5 Anonymous, *Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang woyou tu*), detail of foreground trees, handscroll, ink on paper. Tokyo, National Museum (photo: Malenfer Ortiz)

constitute originally one single discipline" (*shi hua ben yi lü*), Su Shi meant that feelings and description can fuse in mood only if a painting is composed as a poem.¹² He wrote three poems on Song Di's *Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang*, in which he praised the paintings at two levels, namely the natural depiction that arouses the feeling of traveling into the real place, and the lyrical idea that resonates beyond forms.¹³

The one fundamental rule in poetry and painting is natural talent and fresh originality.

Su Shi, *Jizhu fenlei Dongpo xiansheng shi*, in *SBCK*, v, 11: 29a. According to Su, in order to offer the viewer a poetic allusion more evocative than a concrete object presented under his eyes, painting must be imbued with the emotive suggestion of poetry. Painting thus has the potential to provide both verbal signs and visual representation at once, with no subordination. See also Paul Klee, who displayed the "juxtaposition of shapes and the syntax of lines in an uncertain, reversible, floating space (simultaneously page and canvas, planes and volumes, maps and chronicle)," in M. Foucault, *This is not a Pipe* (*Ceci n'est pas une pipe*, 1973), trans. J. Harkness, Berkeley, 1983, 32–33.

¹² *Dongpo quanji*, Meizhou sansici, 1832, 67: 1a.

¹³ Su Shi's poems read successively:

Journeying west I remember the southern kingdom:
In the hall your pictures of the Xiao and Xiang.
In dazzling vision cloudy mountains rise up;
Floating up to the horizon, wilds and waters stretch out.
The mind filled with former travels,
Then skillfully you forgot both hand and brush.
Should a traveler come from Henyang
And see these pictures, his thoughts would be a vast expanse of water.

How upright are your aspirations;
Mountains and streams bend and twist.
You first composed your painting mentally,
Then you brushed it out with no difficulty.
In the river market there are few families;
In the misty village old trees grow in clumps.
I understand you have a subtle idea;
Let me carefully search for it.

There are many feet and inches [of painting];
Cloudy or clearing, the view is not uniform.
Paths coiling run toward the distant mountain,
Waters converging flow into the nearby stream.
You said yourself the idea was not mere imagination,
You actually entered there by horses' hoofs.
Some other year, on an official journey,
Perhaps we'll talk west of Mount Swordgate.



6 Anonymous, *Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang woyou tu*), detail of mountain village, handscroll, ink on paper. Tokyo, National Museum (photo: Malenfer Ortiz)

Consequently, paintings of the Xiao Xiang corresponded to both scholars and painters' understanding that the inner workings of nature constituted the basic principle of both painting and poetry.

In addition to their reference to the subject matter, the colophons written on *Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang* indicate that the painting was produced for a certain Yungu Yuanzhao, who spent most of a peripatetic life in the mountains of China.¹⁴ When Yungu became too old to travel to the famous river site of the Xiao Xiang, he expressed the desire to journey through the region in a dream aided by a painting. In this context, landscape painting functions as a vehicle for imaginary travels in mountainous regions and gives the viewer the same benefits as if he had actually gone there. In his colophon on *Dream Journey*, Ge Bi (fl. late twelfth century) wrote that the hermit commissioned the landscape painting so that he could "travel mentally through it." Later

Dongpo xuji, in *Sibu beiyao*, Taipei: Zhonghua shuju, n.d., 2: 5–6; Chen Gaohua, 322.

¹⁴ Yungu Yuanzhao was a hermit attached to the Chan sect of Buddhism and lived on Mount Jindou, near Wuxing. To my knowledge, however, he is not recorded in any Chan Buddhist lineage. Yungu commissioned several paintings of the Xiao and Xiang, of which *Dream Journey* was his favorite.



7 Attr. Dong Yuan, *Awaiting the Ferry at the Foot of the Mountains in Summer* (*Xiajing shankou daidu tu*), handscroll, ink and light color on silk. Shenyang, Liaoning Provincial Museum (after *Liaoning Bowuguan Canghua*, ed. Yang Renkai and Dong Yangming, Shanghai: Renmin Meishu Chubanshe, 1986)

the Qianlong emperor (r. 1736–1796) wrote a title on the silk frontispiece of the handscroll which means literally “roaming through the Xiao and Xiang while lying down” (*Xiao Xiang woyou*). *Woyou* is a contraction of *woyi youzhi*, “roaming the mountains while lying down,” which translates poetically as “dream journey.” The expression was first associated with Zong Bing (375–443), one of the earliest landscape painters of China and the first artist known for his extended travels to famous mountains as well as for his long sojourn on Mount Heng, in modern Hunan Province, one of the five sacred mountains of China. Once he became too old to climb mountains, he covered the walls of his room with his own paintings of the peaks he loved, so that he would be able to pursue his enjoyment of beautiful sites by viewing his painted walls.¹⁵ Zong Bing and, later, Yungu, conceived of landscape painting as a substitute for the real site, which allowed them to transport themselves into a beloved place by a conscious act of the imagination. Through this contact with nature, Zong was able to “concentrate his vital breath and harmonize his body,” thus nourishing his spiritual and physical well-being.¹⁶ The painting’s verisimilitude and spiritual animation offered the viewer the same qualities inherent in nature, and hence could be used by Zong or by Yungu as a support for meditation. In order to understand the role of a meditative journey in ink, it is essential to address the technical and aesthetic dimensions of pictorial space.

Dream Journey on the Xiao and Xiang represents an exceptional artistic moment in the history of Chinese landscape painting. It depicts a real place desired by all travelers, partakes with poetry in the expression of a dream, and embodies a spiritual journey. First, it is necessary to locate *Dream Journey* within the historical evolution of spatial articulation in Song landscape painting before discussing the particular feature of transitions in the pictorial space of several handscrolls. This spatial analysis, done in conjunction with a reading of the poems, will demonstrate the Southern Song painters’ conscious depiction of space as an object for contemplation. Finally, an examination of the ink technique of *Dream Journey* will enhance understanding of the substance of poetic space and of its power to evoke reverie or daydream.

The Place of Dream Journeys in the History of Song Handscroll Painting

Dream Journey may be placed in the history of landscape painting based on its spatial features. The clearest source of

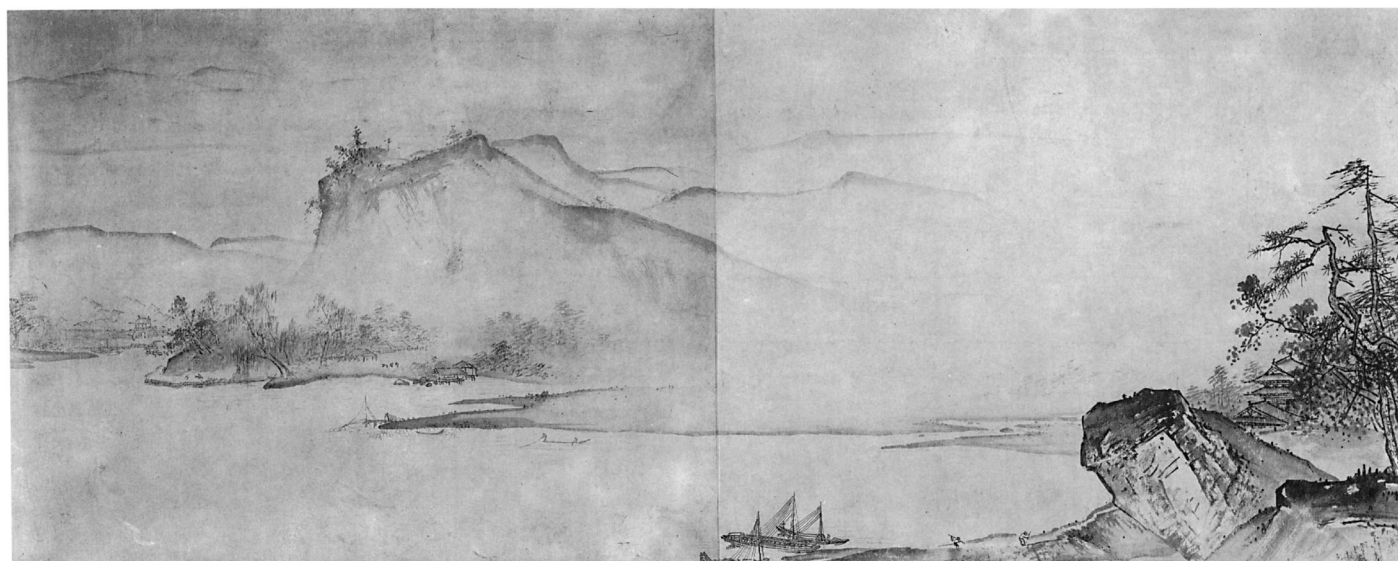
the work’s unified composition is Dong Yuan (d. 962). Its central section is laid out in the form of an inverted triangle (Fig. 1), which refers traditionally to the handscrolls attributed to Dong, such as *Awaiting the Ferry at the Foot of the Mountains in Summer* (*Xiajing shankou daidu tu*, Liaoning Provincial Museum) (Fig. 7).¹⁷ Furthermore, both scrolls engage the viewer in a trip over a variety of lakes, rivers, and low V-shaped banks, as well as over a few mountains, whose dorsal spine is structured in a very similar way. Leading toward the central mountain of *Dream Journey*, and proceeding from the back of the picture toward the front, a low range of mountains meets a middle-ground island, and stretches from a wine house on the right to a traveler crossing a bridge on the left. The succession of shores encloses a bay, whose composition draws a reversed C-shape. This structure is part of a larger plan, originating at the junction of the first two sheets of paper. Approaching the middle range of mountains closing a bay on the left, another bay opens on the right, stretching toward the background until it vanishes into the mists. This second bay draws another C-shape, symmetrically opposed to the first one. This double C-shaped composition finds a clear precedent in Dong Yuan’s painting (Fig. 7).¹⁸ In both scrolls, the range of low mountains receding toward the background is squeezed at the “waist” between the two bays. This structural feature, which gives

¹⁵ Quoted in Zhang Yanyuan, *Lidai minghua ji* (847), fol. 4, cited in ZGHLLB, 583–584. Zong is also said to have written one of the first treatises on landscape painting, *Hua hanshui xu* (*Introduction to Painting Landscape*, ca. 433–443), included in *Lidai minghua ji*, fol. 4; trans. W. Acker, in *Some Tang and Pre-Tang Texts*, Leiden, 1974, II, 115–122; S. Bush and H. Y. Shih, *Early Chinese Texts on Painting*, Cambridge, Mass., 1985, 36–38; M. Sullivan, *The Birth of Landscape Painting in China*, Berkeley, 1962, 102–103.

¹⁶ See Sullivan (as in n. 15), 102. Bearing in mind the role of landscape painting that Zong Bing expressed, Ge Bi, one of the ten writers who inscribed *Dream Journey* in the Southern Song, explained, “Yungu knows how to take it and to delight in it. His ears perceive what others cannot. His breast is almost entirely filled with the Xiao Xiang. Yungu doesn’t need to exit his house, and yet he travels in the Xiao Xiang” (my trans.).

¹⁷ This similarity has been discussed by R. M. Barnhart, *Marriage of the Lord of the River, A Lost Landscape by Tung Yuan*, suppl. of *Artibus Asiae*, 1960, 6–8. In the same study Barnhart proposes a reconstitution of a handscroll attributed to Dong Yuan in reassembling two separate paintings: *Awaiting the Ferry*, and *The Xiao and Xiang Rivers* (*Xiao Xiang tu*, Palace Museum, Beijing).

¹⁸ See Malenfer (as in n. 4), 113–114. A similar comparison between Dong Yuan’s composition and *Dream Journey* was described recently by H. Kunigo, “Shōshō hakkei zukan shōkō: ritō no sansuiga to no kankei ni tsuite,” *Bijutsushi ronshō*, VI, 1990, 41–56.



8 Xia Gui, *Pure and Remote Views of Mountains and Rivers* (*Qishan qingyuan*), handscroll, ink on paper, Taipei, National Palace Museum (photo: Asian Art Photographic Distribution, University of Michigan)

dynamism to the lateral transition from the expanse of water at the beginning of the scroll to the central mountain, illustrates *Dream Journey*'s direct debt to Dong Yuan's compositions.

Dream Journey stands as a major monument that connects the works of Dong Yuan, Mi Fu, and his son Mi Youren¹⁹ in the eleventh and twelfth centuries with the paintings of Zhao Mengfu (1254–1322), Wu Zhen (1280–1354), and Huang Gongwang (1269–1354) in the late thirteenth and fourteenth centuries. Besides the equally important question of ink technique, these handscroll paintings share similar mountain shapes, gently rounded tops of low ranges, and marshy waterlands. These motifs, which became the hallmark of the Southern, or Jiangnan, School of painting, are brilliantly represented in the late twelfth century by *Dream Journey*.

Moreover, the painter of *Dream Journey* was also aware of certain compositional techniques that Northern painters had developed for the hanging scroll format. The central mountain of *Dream Journey* is symmetrical and sits in commanding majesty at the exact center of the handscroll, the ultimate climax of the landscape, where the marriage of peaks and streams is the most elaborate. It serves to anchor the composition, and thus seems to be extracted from a Northern Song hanging scroll, typically stable and clearly organized. *Dream Journey* thus synthesizes two types of composition that have been elaborated by landscape painters since the tenth century. It integrates a seemingly conservative Northern monumental landscape structure within a handscroll format whose spatial continuity reflects the Jiangnan tradition.

Finally *Dream Journey* shares its diagonal construction with Southern Song academy paintings. For instance, the articulation of the different landscape scenes in *Pure and Remote Views of Mountains and Rivers* (*Qishan qingyuan*, National

Palace Museum, Taipei), a handscroll on paper attributed to the court artist Xia Gui (fl. ca. 1220–40), is organized along diagonal lines that permit an easy visual transition from one scene to the next (Fig. 8).²⁰ The diagonal directing lines of the composition, which became the hallmark of the so-called Ma-Xia School, push the dense and empty elements of each scene to opposite corners, thus creating a dramatic asymmetry. They also lead the viewer's eyes beyond the top and bottom boundaries of the scroll, conducting the imagination beyond the painted landscape. Likewise the landscape depicted in *Dream Journey* is framed by two parallel diagonal shores that recede in depth. The successive islets diminishing along a diagonal line toward the upper left of the painting occur twice, once after the central mountain, and once at the end of the scroll (Fig. 4). The painting ends in emptiness, as the low hills recede into depth, with no solid mass in the lower corner for counter-balance. This composition at the end of the scroll contrasts with most of Northern Song or Jin Dynasty (1115–1234) handscrolls, which generally bring the viewer's attention back to the foreground.²¹ The absence of such closure at the end of *Dream Journey*, as in many other Southern Song handscrolls, creates an impression

²⁰ Ma Yuan (fl. 1190–after 1225), the other pillar of early 13th-century court painting, used similar structural devices in his *Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang bajing tu*), transmitted through a copy by the Qing court artist Dong Bangda (1699–1769). The eight scenes are separated by pockets of misty space, thus emphasizing the passage of time, and are linked by the general diagonal direction of the overall composition. Reproduced in J.H. Chou and C. Brown, *The Elegant Brush: Chinese Painting under the Qianlong Emperor, 1735–1795*, Phoenix, Phoenix Art Museum, 1985, 85, cat. no. 26.

²¹ For instance, in a version of *The Red Cliff* (*Chibi tu*) by Wu Yuanzhi (fl. ca. 1190) now in Taipei, one of the best-documented Jin paintings, the composition is framed by a foreground motif at each end. Yet because of the dramatic contrast between these two sections of the foreground with the cliff that rises vertically in the middle ground, this painting can be located around the end of the 12th century. In fact, according to S. Bush, it must already have been in existence by 1195. See his "'Clearing after Snow in the Min Mountains' and Chin Landscape Painting," *Oriental Art*, n.s. xi, 1965, 171.

¹⁹ See esp. a handscroll by Mi Youren, *Cloudy Mountains* (*Yunshan tu*), dated 1130 in an inscription signed by the artist. Handscroll, ink, lead white, and light color on silk, Cleveland Museum of Art.

of infinitude. Thus, the answer brought by Southern Song painters to the problem of depth and of visual continuity is marked by both the diagonal direction and the contrast between near and far. This use of the diagonal in *Dream Journey* suggests that the artist knew, besides the traditional Northern Song structure, the latest trends in spatial articulation that developed in the mid- to late twelfth century in the imperial academy of painting.²²

In addition to the structural devices of asymmetry and centered composition that confirm the place of the painting within the history of Southern Song landscape painting, *Dream Journey* also presents spatial transitions that invite the viewer to read the space between its different parts according to a particular order, which can be called poetic. Thus it can be said that by the end of the twelfth century, space has become the object of seeing, and because this is true in both painting and poetry, poetic space is a very concrete reality.

The Poetic Structure of Space in Southern Song Handscroll Painting

Southern Song pictorial space reads as a poem by virtue of two fundamental features. The first is a limitation of scope, which helps the viewer to focus on a small number of things depicted under particular circumstances. The second characteristic, directly opposed to the first, is an attempt to represent the immense and the infinite, compelling the viewer to visualize the farthest reaches of the depicted space. To focus one's vision in paintings, whose space is either limited or immense, means to look with intensity in order to activate and facilitate the mental operation of seeing. This visual activity is central to Song painting. The visual shifts from the minute and reduced to the infinite and expanded, which can occur within the same composition, necessitate the structural device of separation. The images are clipped and are connected only through the imagination. However, some painters, researching ways by which elements are related in nature, attempt to unify space rather than to separate it in sequences. In the twelfth century, landscape handscroll compositions, whose evolution is particularly significant for the understanding of space, follow two different modes of organization, both of which contribute to the impression of the visually true and poetically convincing: they are separate views or a unified panorama.

Although most of Southern Song handscrolls share asymmetrical features, their overall structures can present significant differences. For instance, the compositions of Xia's *Pure and Remote Views* and *Dream Journey* differ for one major

reason. The transitions along diagonal lines are progressive and generally smooth in *Dream Journey*, but there are intense dramatic shifts in *Pure and Remote Views*, an orchestration of transitions from a close-up view of a boulder to a distant view of mountain silhouettes, presenting a spatial contrast that effectively helps the viewer shift his gaze (Fig. 8). Each segment, isolated from the next by rocks and trees, focuses on an independent view seen at a particular time and from a particular vantage point. The theatrical effect of such windows creates an apparent contradiction as the perception fluctuates between the space that is represented and framed and the space that structures such presentation. This shift of perception typifies space in late twelfth- and thirteenth-century painting of the imperial academy.

The succession of separate views of landscape developed already in early twelfth-century handscrolls;²³ it occurred most dramatically in conjunction with the development of themes such as the *Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang*, a work originally conceived as a grouping of independent views. The first Southern Song emperor Gaozong (r. 1127–62) commissioned Wang Hong (fl. mid-twelfth century), a hitherto obscure painter, to depict the theme.²⁴ Wang Hong's *Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang bajing tu*, Princeton University Museum of Art), the earliest set existing today, is a combination of eight separate units on pieces of silk, which, according to Alfreda Murck, have since been cut and reassembled in an order different from the original one given by Shen Gua (Fig. 9).²⁵ Each section is as much an evocation of one of the poetic titles through narrative details and atmospheric effects as a reference to a master of the Northern Song through motifs and composition. Through this catalogue of styles of the past, the artist stresses the separation of each landscape scene to a degree greater than had been seen before the Eight Views were conceived.

In contrast to paintings of the Ma-Xia tradition, those belonging to the Jiangnan tradition offered unified panoramas, of which *Dream Journey* stands as the best representative in the Southern Song. Although *Dream Journey* shares with court paintings certain descriptive details typical of the Eight Views, its aim is to unify in a single bird's-eye view the eight

²² Similarly *The Red Cliff* (*Chibi tu*) in the Boston Museum of Fine Arts, attributed to Yang Shixian (fl. ca. 1120–60), presents a diagonal line that stretches into nothing. Yet the overall composition is split in two sections: the first half is filled with a cliff in the middle ground and by contrast the second half is occupied with water and distant mountains. Another example, *Ten Thousand Pines on a River Shore* (*Wansong jinyan tu*) in Beijing, attributed to Zhao Bosu (1124–82), a court artist contemporary with the author of *Dream Journey*, presents a similar feature, though the general layout is exactly reversed, as the empty space occupies the beginning of the handscroll. This painting may be a fine work of the period, though probably not by Zhao. See J. Cahill, *Index of Early Chinese Paintings and Painters*, Berkeley, 1980, 68. This construction signals that the three compositions, if not the paintings themselves, belong roughly to that time.

²³ For instance, the anonymous *Streams and Mountains without End* (*Qishan wujin*, Cleveland Museum of Art), probably to be dated around 1125, presents a series of landscape scenes, each one being an independent stylistic study of a great master. The composition is given continuity by means of successive masses and voids strung on a middle-distance line represented by paths which, like unmistakable channels, lead the viewer through the landscape. For a thorough study of the scroll and its dating, see S. Lee and W. Fong, *Streams and Mountains without End*, suppl. of *Artibus Asiae*, 1977, 2–3. See also the more recent interpretation of the painting's style as iconography by S. Bush in "Yet Again, *Streams and Mountains without End*," *Artibus Asiae*, 1988, 197–223. The rhythmic presentation of views is also remarkable in a handscroll, *Fishermen* (*Yufu*), attributed to Xu Daoning (1000–after 1066). The unrolling of *Fishermen* reveals high peaks after deep and low valleys in a sequential pattern. However, the movement of the viewer's eyes along *Fishermen* can only go up and down on a flat plane, as opposed to the movement into depth characteristic of landscapes from the late 12th century onward.

²⁴ Only a brief reference to Wang Hong is given by Xia Wenyan (1296–1370), who notes that Wang was a man of Shu (Sichuan), and that during the Shaoxing era (1131–62) he painted landscapes after Fan Kuan. *Tuhua baojian*, in *HSCS*, 2: 89.

²⁵ Murck (as in n. 8), 213–236.



9 Wang Hong, *Eight Views of the Xiao Xiang (Xiao and Xiang bajing tu)*. "Returning Sails off Distant Shores," one of eight handscrolls, ink on silk. Princeton University Museum of Art (photo: Museum)

scenes, whose referential poetic phrases are sometimes difficult to identify. One of the handscroll's most distinctive features is the continuity of the development of its successive views, each one focusing on a specific scene, whether a bay, a group of hills, a temple, or a village, and yet always visually consistent with the bird's-eye view. The themes are connected to each other by spatial devices and by the wet treatment of the ink which fuses the different elements. A careful examination of the scroll indicates that all the Eight Views are present. Reading the scroll from right to left, the following order of titles can be proposed:

8. Fishing Village in Twilight Glow
7. Evening Bell from Mist-Shrouded Temple
6. Night Rain on Xiao and Xiang
5. Autumn Moon over Lake Dongting
3. Mountain Market in Clearing Mist
4. River and Sky in Evening Snow
1. Wild Geese Descending to Sandbar
2. Returning Sails off Distant Shores.

(The numbers preceding the titles correspond to Shen Gua's order.) It appears that in *Dream Journey* the sequence is almost exactly opposite the original one. A detailed study of a set of Ming paintings on the Eight Views has shown the importance of the pairing of the titles as couplets, following the conventional pattern of regulated verse, which contains eight lines of even length, with either five characters or seven characters to a line.²⁶ Hence the group of titles would constitute a complete structure of *lu shi*, the regulated verse most highly praised by the Chinese. Within such a structure, the eight lines are divided into four couplets, which means that the lines function two by two, the first line introducing the topic and the second one developing the theme or contrasting it. Shen Gua's lines form pairs in their original order. Similarly in *Dream Journey*, the same poetic phrases are also grouped two by two following the original groupings, even though the lines have sometimes been inverted within the couplets. Opening the scroll, the fishing village emerging from the glow typical of twilight is a prelude to the evening atmosphere through which a temple bell resonates. The bay that follows, bathed in rain, opens toward the right, contrasting with the juxtaposed bay that turns toward the left and encircles Lake Dongting. Then, lines three and four come as a pair in which the mountain market is contrasted

with the river and sky, echoed in the painting by a high mountain followed by a long stretch of distant shores. This grandiose view over the central mountains constitutes the heart of the painting, reflecting the third and traditionally the most important couplet of the poem. Finally, the last couplet signals distant geese and distant sails, both indicating a return, either in autumn or at the end of the day. Understanding that the two final lines of a regulated verse generally separate themselves from the rest of the poem and require a different tone, the painter suggests this fading moment by a smooth line that recedes toward the distant left of the painting and dies into infinitude.

Dream Journey's painter was aware of the very precise rules that governed Song poetry. He was a learned artist who, like most of Southern Song painters, must have expended much effort studying poetry. His handscroll mirrors the structure of an eight-line poem, a complex aesthetic requirement characteristic of Song taste. Although a few elements, such as the temple in the mist, the fishing village, and the landing geese, are reminiscent of the poetic titles, *Dream Journey's* leading principle is not to match Shen Gua's titles literally, nor to present a variety of exercises in the styles of earlier painters; rather, the aim is to create visual effects so that the perception of the space itself can arouse poetic resonances in the viewer's mind. In contrast to clearly separated views, which eventually became too rigid and were criticized for having lost the suggestive manner that had been Song Di's inspiration, free from any preconceived theme, *Dream Journey* presents a unified space centered on a mountain in which the scenes interlock.²⁷ Because the depiction of each view is subordinated both to a structure that recalls the laws of poetry and to an overall unifying composition in the Southern style, *Dream Journey* reaches beyond the narrative of the

²⁶ A. Murck, "Ming Interpretations of the Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang," paper presented at the "International Symposium on Chinese Painting from the Palace Museum, Peking," Cleveland Museum of Art, May 6–7, 1989. For the analysis of regulated verse, see Y. K. Kao, "The Aesthetics of Regulated Verse," in *The Vitality of the Lyric Voice: Shih Poetry from the Late Han to the T'ang*, ed. S. F. Lin and S. Owen, Princeton, 1986, 332–385. Regarding the concept of Chinese aesthetics by Kao, see Yu Kung, "Chinese Lyric Aesthetics," in *Words and Images*, 47–90.

²⁷ See, for instance, Zhao Xigu's following comment, "Song Fugu [Di] painted *Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang Rivers*. Originally they had no predetermined titles. Later people gave them names such as 'Autumn Moon over Lake Dongting'; nowadays painters who first choose titles are not gentlemen (*shifu*);" in *Dongtian qinglu ji*, in *MSCS*, 1/9, 4: 27a.

Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang to the atmosphere of the region and to its poetry.

The success of the poetic effect of *Dream Journey* results from both its arrangement of the eight views and its broad vision transcending each particular view. A carefully controlled, time-consuming effort coordinated the painting's general structure and its details. Such coherence indicates that the artist must have started this complicated painting with a few essential mountain contours, laid down in pale ink at the outset. Thus, he established a unified design before defining secondary motifs. It is impossible for the viewer to isolate any one of the views because each chain of hills is incorporated into a greater whole, planned on a large scale. Each bay is part of a group of bays, and both the particular and the general can be perceived depending on the viewpoint adopted. A consistent atmosphere permeates the whole; the transitions along diagonal lines are smooth and almost imperceptible; the landscape evokes a fragile, evanescent moment which a distracted eye could miss, but it affords the viewer a continuous journey over the vast landscape. Because the construction of *Dream Journey* is based upon broad general effects rather than on an accumulation of details, it suggests that space is its primary subject matter.

The Objectification of Poetic Space

Within its broad panorama, *Dream Journey* presents structural features that help one to shift from one mode of perception to another and thus to read the painting as a poem. A comparison can be drawn between the spatial articulation of the work and the illusionistic transitions in one of Yang Wanli's poems, titled "Crossing Lake Boyang on the Thirteenth of the Fourth Month," which reads:

Mount Kanglang stands in the middle of the lake, like a cup floating on the water.

I moor my boat at Prince Bo's lake,²⁸

Wind and rain last until midnight.

Though I want to cross, would I be so daring?

Idle safety is all that I wish.

I know lonely melancholy is useless;

So I endure a while, continuously sighing.

The night is long, and suddenly I fall asleep;

I'm so exhausted I don't know it's dawn.

The boatmen call me to get up;

The wind is favorable; time is pressing.

In less than an oar-stroke I've already reached mid-lake

My boat is a single leaf on a mirror's surface.

I look up and see the clouds' robes open;

I glance sideways as the sail's belly fills.

The sky is like a glazed bell,

Which covers over this crystal cup below.

The waves' reflection—splashing gold juices;

The sun's rays—penetrating silver pillars.

Mount Kang is a cup;

Mount Lu a curtain in front of our sail.

Suddenly the earth has no support;

Everything's hazy like a shoreless sea.

My body seems to become void and empty;

Riding the air, I wander far and wide.

At first I worried I'd crash against perilous waves;

I didn't expect this marvelous scene.

During the last six summers and winters

I went on this water three times.

Before crossing, my mind is never at ease;

But while I cross, I always enjoy it.

I'm tired of wandering and ought to go home;

And not just because of the complaints of apes and cranes!²⁹

Yang's poem and *Dream Journey* share principles of structure and of mood. In both cases the reader experiences shifts of perspective that correspond to changes of state of mind. Both painting and poem offer a trip on rivers and lakes, and center on the discovery of a mountain. The central mountain of *Dream Journey*, which stands erect, occupying the total height of the scroll, finds an echo in Yang's poem. In fact, the subtitle of the poem indicates that the main landmark is Mount Kanglang, that it is located at the center of the lake, and that it is shaped "like a cup floating on the water." Then, the poem describes the mood of the poet upon his trip leading to and departing from the mountain, which stands, at the middle of the poem, again in the form of a cup. The short central verse integrating brief images of the mountain and its surroundings is the climax of the poetic journey. Similarly, *Dream Journey's* central mountain is the goal of the trip for the figures traveling through the landscape, and the small pavilion painted in the foreground indicates, as explained in further detail below, that the center is indeed a place for the traveler to stop and look at the mountain. Both poem and painting begin with the description of a flat river crossed by lonely boats. At the end of the journey, both landscapes regain the quiet appearance of their beginning. In the poem the boatman is tired of these long years spent wandering and he longs to go home. The final section of *Dream Journey*, which depicts a river fading in the mist, conveys a melancholic mood of endless, almost aimless travels echoed by the colophons dedicated to the patron of the painting, Yungu Yuanzhao, whose life had been a continuous series of trips through the mountains and rivers of southern China. Like the poet, Yungu is tired of traveling in search of the Way and he longs to return home.

The continuous structure of *Dream Journey* helps the viewer build up his expectations of the central mountain, to dwell there for a while in imagination, and to leave the mountain for restful lowlands filled with misty villages. Both arrival to and departure from the mountain are progressive. As in the middle of the poem by Yang Wanli quoted earlier, the shift in vision and in mood depicted at the center of *Dream Journey* is smooth and does not disrupt the harmonious unity of the landscape. In both instances, the various elements of nature are not viewed in isolation but in relation

²⁸ Lake Boyang, located in northern Jiangxi province, is one of the great lakes of China. The expression "Prince Bo's lake," used by Yang in the poem, is another name for it.

²⁹ Yang Wanli, 1276. See another translation by J. D. Schmidt in *Yang Wanli*, Boston, 1976, 104.

to each other. This is to be expected in any skillful natural description, and amounts to saying that in each one, the poem and the painting, the vision is well unified. The sky in the poem reflects the gold waves and the silver sun rays like a crystal cup which complements the cup that is Mount Kanglang. The images of the poem glisten before they suddenly vanish for “the earth has no support.” Similar in character to these instantaneous images, the washlike forms of *Dream Journey* appear and disappear through the haze. Nevertheless, all the different parts remain connected and blend together, skillfully orchestrated in a large-scale composition that maintains its tight unity. In both the painting and the poem, the different sections of the landscape are observed from different angles, but the travelers wandering through each one of them are aware of the hierarchical unity. The smoothness of the shifts have a suggestive quality that creates an aura of dream and recollection.

The idea of rest and contemplation is revealed by the pavilion retreat from which the traveler of *Dream Journey* can enjoy the most comprehensive view of the landscape (Figs. 2, 3). He can extend his gaze far up to the top of the mountain as well as far down along the river running below. The spatial construction of that central section, though apparently unified, presents in its complexity a case typical of Southern Song experiments with perception. This space stirs a poetic response from the viewer first because it draws him into a mental association with the figure painted within the pavilion, thus suggesting a particular way to “read” the space around this figure, and second because its immensity conveys a mood characteristic of those voyages into infinitude that are typically depicted in Song poems. The visual effect of this segment of the painting must be analyzed first.

The central section of *Dream Journey* is structured about two vanishing points which are not aligned: the focal point passing through the pavilion is lower than that passing through the landscape behind it (Fig. 2). The first focal point offers a continuity of ground plane from the exterior to the interior of the painting. It is a response of the viewer who interprets it from a comparison with his own experience of scale; hence it is empirical. The second one concerns a zone of a more grandiose scale, far remote from the viewer, and theoretical. The conflict between the two structures is in one sense spatial, a clash between two viewing systems; yet in a wider sense it is a clash between contradictory definitions of the viewer. On the one hand, there is a physical connection between the viewer and the pavilion. On the other hand, the viewer looks at the far distant mountain from a non-empirical point of observation. *Dream Journey* is antithetical to the “rational order” of Li Cheng (919–967), which Shen Gua, who is knowledgeable in various scientific disciplines as well as in the arts of calligraphy and painting, criticizes:

When Li Cheng painted such buildings as pavilions or towers on a mountain, he always did the flying eaves as if one were looking up at them. The explanation is given that one is viewing what is above from below, just like a man on level ground looking up at house eaves sees their supporting rafters. This theory is wrong. . . . Master Li apparently did not understand the method of taking the



10 Li Cheng, *A Solitary Temple amid Clearing Peaks* (*Qingluan xiaosi*), hanging scroll, ink and light color on silk. Kansas City, Nelson-Atkins Museum of Art (photo: Museum)

larger view of the small, but his distinctions of height and distance naturally had a subtle rational order.³⁰

Shen Gua disapproves of Li Cheng's painting temple eaves as if seen from one fixed viewpoint and not integrated into the “larger view” of the picture. In the hanging scroll attributed to Li, *A Solitary Temple amid Clearing Peaks* (*Qingluan xiaosi*, The Nelson-Atkins Museum of Art, Kansas City), the central temple located at the middle of the height of the

³⁰ *Mengqi bitan*, fol. 17, quoted in *ZGHLB*, 625, trans. Bush and Shih (as in n. 15), 112.

great peak stands on its own and invites the viewer to look at it head on, establishing a relationship that is inconsistent with the other parts of the painting (Fig. 10). For instance, the lines of recession, which converge toward this temple roof and follow the drawing of its eaves seen from below, prevent the viewer from perceiving all the layers of the distant mountains. Shen Gua's ideal of integrating multiple viewpoints within one frame is an artistic vision, not what vision can empirically embrace in one glance. Shen might have found in *Dream Journey* a truer image of a landscape, in that the dual viewpoints of the central section are fully harmonized with the rest of the composition, as the envelope of misty space allows smooth transitions from one view to the next, thus representing the immensity of a scene free from the laws of a rational order. In *Dream Journey*, the mode of perception is not restricted to an addition of single points of view, but rather involves a fluctuating experience of the world. The articulation of space, that is, the constantly shifting horizon line and angle of vision along the handscroll, refers to the dynamic re-creation, by the viewer, of the natural landscape as a spatial and temporal continuum within which one's horizon line constantly changes depending on where one stands. The painting offers to the viewer's eyes several means to move within the landscape. Because the point of observation is a traveling one, the imaginary voyager can proceed along the handscroll according to the "three distances" (high, deep, and low) and, then, upon his rest in the middle of the scroll, he benefits from a dual perspective that allows him to see more than he would if there were only one single vanishing point. This pictorial excursion offers the viewer a feeling of walking in, dwelling in, being surrounded by, moving about the landscape, and resting for contemplation. This image, ordered by the laws of visual coherence, obeys the theory of atmospheric "distances" coined by Han Zhuo (fl. ca. 1095–1125) and stands in striking contrast with the additive structures of Li Cheng and Guo Xi (ca. 1001–ca. 1090).³¹ At this stage of discoveries in spatial articulation, the painter is concerned with the viewer's observation of space as an object of curiosity.

The shift from what is seen to the one who sees, which is typical of Southern Song painting in general and of *Dream Journey* in particular, is an essential characteristic of poetry. It

also occurs in Yang Wanli's poem where it leads to a shift of mood. Yang articulates this transition between two sets of worlds by discussing "how" he sees the world. In the poem, upon approaching Mount Kanglang, when the boatman says, "I look up," and then "I glance sideways," his imagination is overwhelmed by the sight of the mountain. Yang explicitly indicates the process by which he looks at the landscape and then feels as if "his body were empty" and as if he were "riding the air" and "wandering far and wide." The realization of a vast view in the poem corresponds to the shift in perspective at the center of *Dream Journey*, and in both cases illustrates a shift of mood and consciousness from an ordinary trip where the traveler is assimilated to any one of the fishermen to a contemplation of the magnificent mountain, whose imposing stature incites a feeling of timelessness and a recollection of previous trips.

One fundamental aspect of this iconography of space is the representation of the viewer of that space. Southern Song landscape paintings often conveyed the idea of contemplation or dream through the integration of figures in the environment they are dreaming about. For instance, an anonymous depiction of "The Seventh Month" (*Qiyue tu*), from the *Odes of the State of Bin* (*Mao shi binfeng tu*, The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York), contains several successive actions represented within the same composition, a feature rare in Chinese handscrolls, in contrast to Japanese handscrolls (Fig. 11).³² The landscape depicted on the vertical sides of the bed coincidentally resembles that of *Dream Journey*. The shift of vision from the landscape painted on the sides of the bed to the dreamer himself echoes the shift in *Dream Journey* between the distant mountain and the pavilion. In both cases, there are two viewing systems, the translation of which conveys the idea of a dream world.

The motif of a figure looking at the scenery from a pavilion deserves particular attention. Because the idea of the contemplation of nature is central to the *Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang*, it is natural that most of its versions include a pavilion and a figure pensively looking at the scenery. For instance, in the earliest extant set of the *Eight Views*, executed by Wang Hong, "Returning Sails off Distant Shores" (*Yuanpu fangui*) depicts a figure leaning on the railing of a small pavilion, as if stretching the view toward the distant reaches of the landscape (Fig. 9). The pavilion depicted halfway behind a tree at the center of *Dream Journey* is drawn in fine clear lines and contrasts with the ink washes used for the rest of the landscape (Fig. 3).³³ One may imagine that, from this

³¹ The theory of the "three distances" was written by Guo Xi and reads as follows, "Mountains have three types of distance. Looking up to the mountain's peak from its foot is called the 'high distance' (*gaoyuan*). From in front of the mountain looking past it to beyond is called 'deep distance' (*shenyuan*). Looking from a nearby mountain at those more distant is called the 'level distance' (*pingyuan*);" in *Linqun gaozhu*, quoted in ZGHLLB, 639. Around 1120, Han Zhuo elaborated on Guo Xi's statement, adding three more distances to the original ones.

Guo Xi wrote that there are Three Distances. . . . I have a theory about three additional ways to represent distance: when from the near bank of a broad body of water, one can see mountains far, far off is called "broad distance" (*guoyuan*); when mists and clouds cloak and obscure, and, cut off by a wilderness stream, one can see almost nothing beyond it, this is called "shrouded distance" (*myuan*); when the objects in a scene are extremely fragmentary and everything is indistinct and shrouded, this is called "mysterious distance" (*youyuan*).

In *Shanshui chunquanj* (author's preface of 1121), quoted in ZGHLLB, 662; trans. adapted from R. M. Barnhart, *Along the Border of Heaven: Sung and Yuan Paintings of the C. C. Wang Collection*, Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, 1983, 80.

³² See H. Kohara, "Narrative Illustration in the Handscroll Format," in *Words and Images*, 247–266.

³³ The pavilion and its location recall earlier paintings, such as the one attributed to Yan Su (961–1040), *Spring Mountains* (*Chunshan tu*), a short handscroll whose reproduction has recently been published in *Huohua bian*, in *Zhongguo meishu quanji*, Beijing: Wenwu, 1988, 1, no. 3, 36. In both cases the pavilion is painted with dark and precise strokes, so that even the figure depicted inside it is visible. Barnhart has stressed the function of figures in landscape. He has suggested that they are a "surrogate for the painter who, in painting them, paints an aspect of himself," thus arguing that the depicted figure is a metaphor for the artist's mind and presence. See "Figures in Landscape," *Archives of Asian Art*, LXII, 1989, 64. Although it is difficult to assert that the depicted figure represents any specific person, it might be suggested that the figure sitting in the central pavilion of *Dream Journey* evokes the act of

privileged standpoint, the figure can observe a vast scenery, from the highest and farthest peaks down to the inside of the nearby houses. The pavilion emerges as a mediating element between what the figure depicted within it can perceive as its proper and secure domain and that larger domain within which it must exist but over which it has no control. It constitutes a pause encouraging the viewer to linger mentally in that place and to invest the mountain stream with all the pleasure of contemplation that he would know if he were actually there.³⁴ Located right at the center of the composition as a most significant point of reference, the pavilion works as the “eye of the painting,” an invitation to the viewer to appreciate the landscape from the standpoint of the depicted figure. It represents the Southern Song painters’ conscious representation of contemplation.

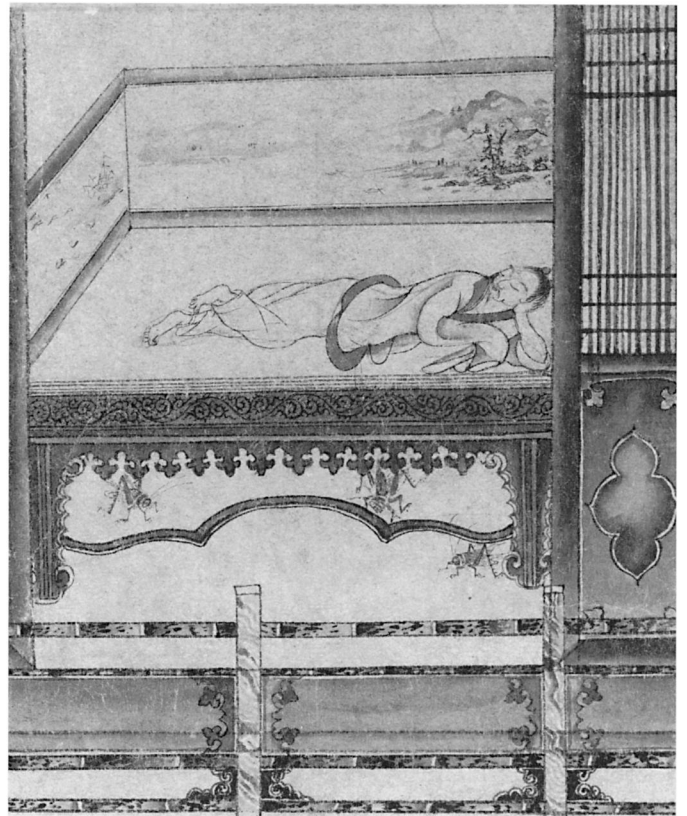
At the turn of the thirteenth century, the figure depicted in contemplation becomes a focal point of landscape compositions and evolves as an object isolated in space. For example, when illustrating Su Shi’s *Red Cliff Ode* (*Chibi tu*, The Nelson-Atkins Museum of Art, Kansas City), Li Song (fl. ca. 1190–ca. 1230) frames the portrait of Su Shi boating as a central solitary point even more significant than the well-known theme of the trip (Fig. 12). The figure viewing nature becomes the focus; the surrounding landscape is reduced to mere background or eliminated completely. The fan format, like that of the album leaf, contributes to the spatial convergence of various lines and makes the viewer conscious of its focus and precision.

The importance of the figure in observation is even more explicitly represented in a large hanging scroll attributed to Ma Lin, *Listening to the Wind in the Pines* (*Qingting songfeng*, National Palace Museum, Taipei) (Fig. 13). The painting depicts a relaxed scholar absorbed in the enjoyment of the cool air circulating below the trees. The picture forces the viewer to concentrate on the figure’s “manner” of contemplation. The depicted scholar’s eyes shift sideward, as if he were willing to communicate with the viewer.³⁵ He should be absorbed in what is happening in the painting, listening to the sound of the wind. Rather, he seems aware of being watched, and he returns to the viewer a glance charged with ambiguity, so that the depicted figure becomes the one who observes. In the Ma Lin hanging scroll, there is a circulation between the two functions of seeing and being seen. In epistemological terms, we can say that the scholar plays the role of signifier, an image into which the spectators in the palace would unceasingly put meaning, which they would extract at will from their political situation, their past history, their dreams, and so forth. The scholar’s glance is the very object of their contemplation, and, because of its infinite circuit of meanings, it is a symbol that permits the figure

dreaming about the Xiao and Xiang scene. It may also represent Yungu, the recipient of the painting.

³⁴ Writing on architectural space, C. Norberg-Schultz noted: “The places are goals, or foci, where we experience the meaningful events of our existence, but they are also points of departure from which we orient ourselves and take possession of the environment.” See *Existence, Space, and Architecture*, New York, 1971, 19.

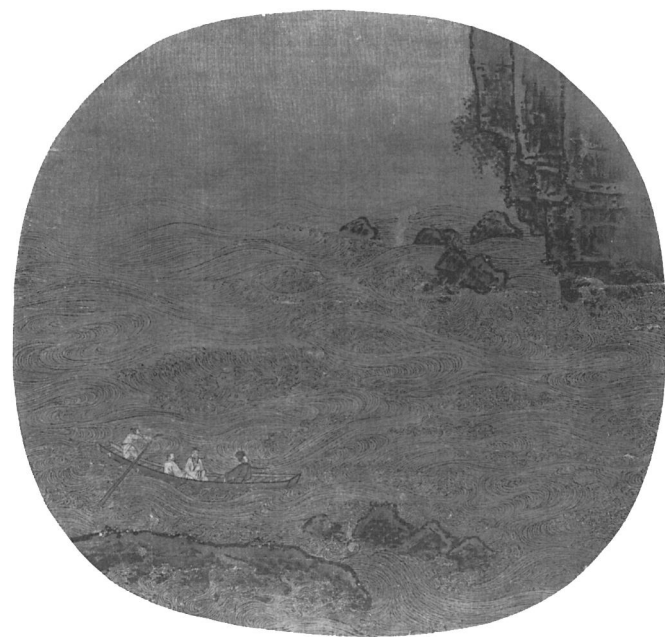
³⁵ See J. Cahill, *The Compelling Image: Nature and Style in Seventeenth Century Chinese Painting*, Cambridge, Mass., 1982, 114.



11 Anonymous, “The Seventh Month” (*Qiyue tu*) from the *Odes of the State of Bin* (*Mao shi binfeng tu*), section of handscroll, ink on paper. New York, Metropolitan Museum of Art, Crawford Collection (photo: Museum)

always to be something other and something much more than a scholar beneath a tree. Ma Lin’s painting was not hung as a souvenir or as the illustration of a sophisticated culture. Rather, it materialized an imagination, a way to look at things.

In late Song, the pictorial space that surrounds the figure in contemplation conveys an aura of dream. Many compositions are characterized by an ambiguous background, which appears as an immaterial curtain drawn along a diagonal. One of the main explorers of that possibility is Liang Kai (fl. ca. 1201–1204), whose fan paintings, such as *Strolling on a Marshy Bank* (*Zepang xingyin*, The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York), often present a small human figure in the midst of a mysterious, almost haunting landscape (Fig. 14). In this case the scholar strolls along a small section of a bank on the lower right-hand corner, while the upper half of the fan is filled with what could be understood either as a huge overhanging cliff or, farther into the background, as a heavy misty sky. Only a few washes located below that cliff suggest a stable horizontal riverbank, while the rest of the scene seems to be floating in the air. In this case, the diagonal structure serves to divide the painting between a human rational world and a mysterious one that ought to be interpreted as a visualized dream. Liang Kai pushed to an extreme degree the search for expressive space that early thirteenth-century court painters such as Li Song, Ma Yuan, and Xia Gui had begun investigating about one generation before him, and that Yuan painters would soon abandon after they discovered



12 Li Song, *The Red Cliff (Chibi tu)*, signed, album leaf mounted as a hanging scroll, ink and light color on silk. Kansas City, Nelson-Atkins Museum of Art (photo: Museum)

the possibilities of rendering space mainly through brushwork. The space backing the long figure strolling on a marshy bank or that extending beyond the pavilion of *Dream Journey* is the object of the dreamer's gaze; such a quality in the painting is emphasized by the contemplative figure.

It is fair to say that the Southern Song offers some of the most contemplative images of Chinese art. Landscape paintings are often made for contemplation; their space becomes a medium for the viewer's contemplation because it is poetic, that is, it evokes a relation between the inner and the outer world, between scene (*jing*) and sentiment (*qing*). There is a new sensitivity to the relationship between the landscape and the figures, which are depicted in contemplation within the landscape and thus contribute to the objectification of space. These figures point to a faraway that extends infinitely and to an impenetrable past. Also, the misty, seemingly unlimited vistas suggest melancholic thoughts and a desire to travel, and they give a lyrical tone to space. It is as if nature is corrected, depicted at its best for comfortable viewing. As seen in *Dream Journey*, the interplay between the mountain and the pavilion attracts the viewer's gaze up and down and, through a minimum of means, creates a tension that helps one to visualize a dream journey. For these reasons, Southern Song poetic space has a psychological effect on the viewer and, as the theme of viewing becomes explicit, it compels him to question his relation to the painted landscape. A dream landscape is all the more effective for drawing the viewer into deep contemplative thoughts; it becomes the support for a self-conscious voyage.

The Pictorial Features of the Poetry of Dreams

In contrast to most court paintings, the Jiangnan solution to the depiction of poetic ideas through pictorial space was developed by painters who lived in the region prior to the southward move of the Song court and who had established a



13 Ma Lin, *Listening to the Wind in the Pines (Qingting songfeng)*, signed and dated 1246, hanging scroll, ink and color on silk. Taipei, National Palace Museum (photo: Asian Art Photographic Distribution, University of Michigan)

tradition of their own. It is to be expected that Southern painters particularly favored the theme of the *Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang*, since the actual landscape resembled their own. Living within a world of misty rivers and marshes, they became familiar with the appearance of objects seen through humid and often blurred atmospheric conditions. They were intrigued by the total effect of the landscape unified through a composition that was both centered and gradually receding into depth.

In painting, as in the poetry of landscape, Southern Song artists were interested in the viewing effects of the progres-

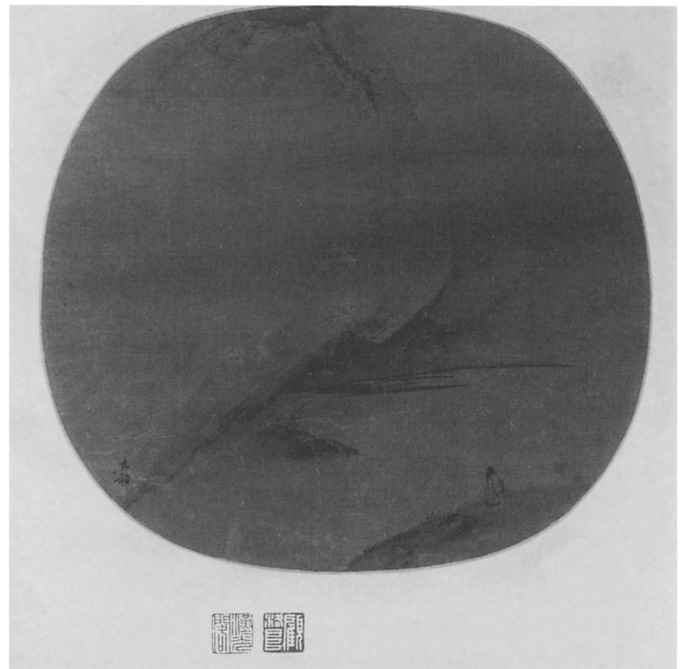
sion of dream images, sometimes ending in a final awakening. In 1204 Lu You wrote a seven-character Regulated Verse describing a leisurely walk in early summer.

Thin clouds hide the sun, day cannot clear up,
Wild waters enter the lake, gradually grow calm.
Verdant leaves now lower, notice a bird is landing,
Green duckweeds slightly move, feel a fish swimming.
Drunkenly roaming in total abandon ignoring my
destination,
Awaking to freedom and ecstasy hard to describe.
Suddenly meet a fisherman secluded in lakes,
Together clasp hands and laugh enjoying our full
lives.³⁶

The light is soft, the atmosphere is misty, and the elements of nature seem to merge; the landscape reflects the sleepy dream of the poet. In addition, changes occur gradually, such as the river merging with the lake, the leaves lowering, or the duckweeds moving. These progressive changes of perspective are essentially matters of space that are echoed in Jiangnan unified handscroll compositions. This space transmits the poetic mood often associated with Southern landscapes, especially that of the Xiao Xiang of *Dream Journey*, whose Eight Views are compressed into a single image to suggest the entire poetic world of the South. This Jiangnan variation on the theme displays technical and structural features that, first, bring us very close to Song Di's original ideal of a poetic landscape and, second, represent an ideal vision of the Southern Song domain now restricted to the South. These features are characterized by the continuous development of the composition and by the fluidity of the ink work. The three major characteristics of Southern Song poetic space for dreams are the visually "real," the unlimited, and the illusory. These spatial features can be explained in relation to the poetry of dreams characteristic of the period.

"Real Landscape"

The bird's-eye view of a real site helps the viewer mentally to combine well-known landmarks and to dream about them as if he were traveling there. Besides *Dream Journey*, another example of a bird's-eye view is *The West Lake at Hangzhou* (*Xihu tu*, Shanghai Museum), an impressionist vision of a real place that fits within the Jiangnan landscape style, attributed to the thirteenth-century artist Li Song (Fig. 15). At first, Li Song's panorama of the West Lake informs the viewer about the actual site of Hangzhou, for which the painting could be called a "topographical landscape," that is, a faithful depiction of a real place. Another painting that can be dated to the Southern Song, though attributed to Juran (fl. ca. 960–980), can also be seen as a topographical depiction of the Yangzi River, a handscroll now in the Freer Gallery. However, the handscroll of *A Panorama of the Yangzi River* (*Changjiang wanli*



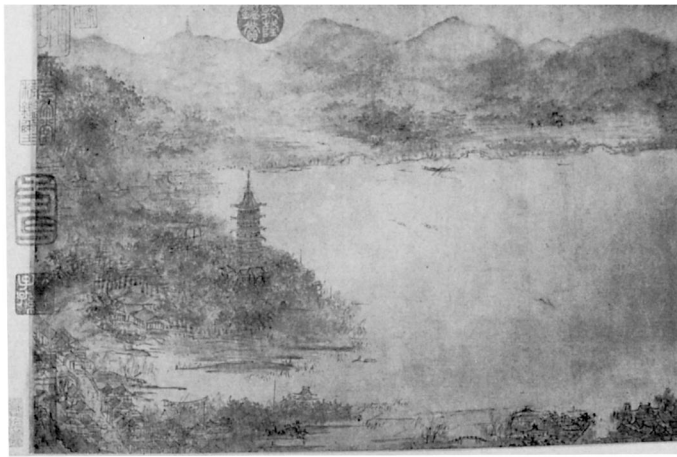
14 Liang Kai, *Strolling on a Marshy Bank* (*Zepang xingyin*), fan mounted as an album leaf, ink on silk. New York, Metropolitan Museum of Art, Crawford Collection (photo: Museum)

tu) features the different spots in conventional and systematic ways as on a map.³⁷ The reading of the painting triggers recognition of the places rather than an aesthetic response; it indicates concern for the exact description of topography. Li Song, though also interested in the topography of the West Lake, employs by contrast two types of technique that make the painting more than just a map. First, he uses light ink washes to blur the scenery and, second, he uses a high vantage point, offering a privileged view as if that of a dream. The viewer can see more than he would if he were to stand on the promontory located somewhere below the foreground, and he does not need to travel mentally along the scroll; and further, he sees things through a hazy atmosphere, the way objects would actually appear if he were to contemplate the scene long enough. More than successions of separate topographical scenes, *West Lake* and *Dream Journey* are unified panoramas whose sections are linked by elements of passage, such as bridges, islands, and forms receding into the mists. This experience of passage from point to point within a bird's-eye view helps the viewer to remember a journey to a well-known place. In addition, the parts of the landscape that do not appear as clearly as on a map, but somewhat indistinctly, trigger in his memory the feeling of being there and elicit, as poetry does, the melancholy of missing that place.

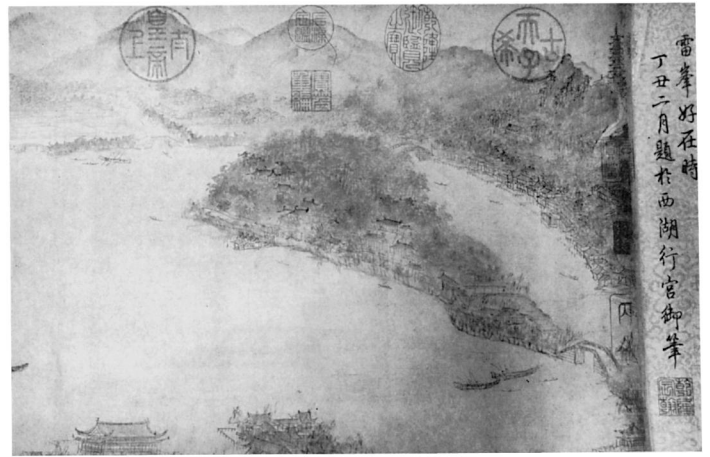
In a similarly topographical fashion, in 1173 Lu You wrote a poem entitled "Happiness Studio" (*Yizhai*), in which he described the East Lake in Suzhou, Sichuan, where he had been sent with his family for official duty.

³⁶ "Chuxia xianbu cunluojian," Lu You, 1914, 61: 871.

³⁷ The painting is reproduced in O. Siren, *Chinese Paintings in American Collections*, Paris and Brussels, 1927–28, 82.



15 Li Song, *The West Lake at Hangzhou (Xihu tu)*, signed, handscroll, ink on paper. Shanghai Museum (photo: Asian Art Photographic Distribution, University of Michigan)



East Lake by midsummer, wild grasses and trees,
 An old room with no guest, cool mid-day pavilion.
 Lilies about to bloom hidden from the sun;
 Bamboo shoots peel off whispering softly.
 Wild ivy twists, turns, filters through window cracks;
 Moist mildew profusely grows on roof beams.
 Trenches covered by a few branches, most secretly
 secluded;
 Water flowed to the threshold, rain damaged the walls.
 Quietly soaking, green weeds dance with water grasses;
 Leisurely roosting, white egrets swim with mandarin
 ducks.
 Lotus petals very fragile though still thick and lush;
 Turquoise cloak dazzling the eyes hides red complexion.
 I must roll up the water-wrinkled precious mat;
 Too languid to unwrap moon-round white fan.
 Heaven wind suddenly sends pagoda bell's sound,
 Wakes me from pure reverie roaming Xiao and Xiang.³⁸

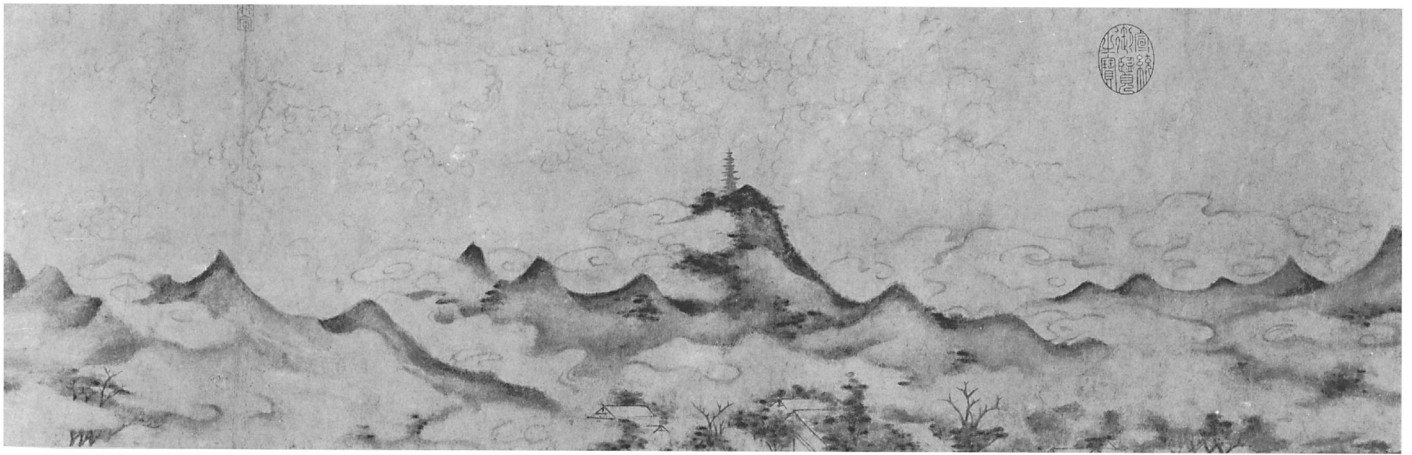
The main portion of Lu You's poem is a minute description of a small tableau that is his studio, isolated, quiet, leisurely. The poem thus belongs to the particular category of "true landscape" poetry. It is as precisely detailed as Li Song's *West Lake*, and both the poem and the painting record the impression of truly being there by offering the reader sensory hints about the real place. Then, the last couplet compares the view of East Lake, which he can enjoy from his window, to the Xiao Xiang. The reference is clearly made to one of the Eight Views, the "Sound of the bell from mist-shrouded temple," a poetic signal of the Xiao Xiang. This is an obvious compliment, as the poet feels secluded in Sichuan, far from the central and eastern Yangzi region. Although Lu You never traveled closer to the Xiao Xiang than to Southern Hubei, by that time the reference to the Xiao Xiang had become an expression of an ideal place for a

cultivated and a beautiful retreat. Also the Xiao Xiang has become synonymous with the dream, a way to embellish imaginatively the place where one dwells. In poetry of the late twelfth-early thirteenth century, dream is often conveyed through a detailed description of a real place. The visual sensation of a topographical landscape arouses dreams about other landscapes one longs for.

Finally, the viewer's recognition of the real place becomes less important than the dream it initiates. Another depiction of the West Lake near Hangzhou can be found in two handscrolls painted by Mi Youren, probably between 1142 and his death in 1151 when in Hangzhou. They are titled *Grasping the Idea of Cloudy Mountains (Yunshan deyi)*, National Palace Museum, Taipei (Fig. 16), and *White Clouds along the Xiao and Xiang (Xiao Xiang baiyun tu)*, in the Shanghai Museum.³⁹ At first these two handscrolls seem to present generic landscapes of clouds and hills. Yet the single pagoda, located at the center of each handscroll, indicates one of the most famous landmarks of Hangzhou; it works here as a unique reminder of the city, in contrast to Li Song's more detailed description. Each one of Mi's compositions is a bird's-eye view, which allows the viewer to survey dreamlike silhouettes of hills painted in pale ink. Mi Youren's views of Hangzhou and *Dream Journey* share a similar general design indicative of the Jiangnan tradition, which anchors the aerial view to a central motif, here a pagoda or a pavilion. In addition, the three paintings, all of them commissioned to convey a mental journey to a coveted location, depict less the actual place than the effect of dreaming about it. The high vantage point over an ocean of light ink washes conveys the idea of dream itself. Poetry easily creates trips into distant places, into the past, or the realm of myth, and the painted landscape of distant and unified views is similarly poetic. The paintings, though reminiscent of two beautiful sceneries, invite the viewer to withdraw there in dream. They are the pictorial expression of a poetic idea.

³⁸ Seven-character Ancient Verse poem. Lu You, 5: 80–81. Also translated by M. Duke in *Lu You*, Boston, 1977, 122. The eleventh line evokes the sunlight reflected from the lotus leaves, which "dazzle the eyes" (*zhaoyan*) and hide the red complexion (*hongzhuang*) of the lotus petals like a "turquoise cloak" (*cui'ai*). These colorful images refer to feminine beauty.

³⁹ Both have been studied by P. Sturman, "Mi Youren and the Inherited Literati Tradition," Ph.D. diss., Yale University, 1989, 410–411. *Xiao Xiang baiyun tu* is reproduced in Sun Zubai, *Mi Fu yu Mi Youren*, in *Zhongguo huajia congshu*, Shanghai: Shanghai renmin meishu chubanshe, 1982, figs. 11–12.



16 Mi Youren, *Grasping the Idea of Cloudy Mountains* (*Yunshan deyi*), handscroll, ink on paper. Taipei, National Palace Museum (photo: Asian Art Photographic Distribution, University of Michigan)

Yet *West Lake* and *Delight in Cloudy Mountains*, though both panoramic views over hazy landscapes, have one major difference in their poetic implications. Mi Youren's views of cloudy mountains are not true topographical landscapes, but a sophisticated evocation through brushwork of a landscape historically cultivated by the class of scholars. Eventually the viewer of *Delight in Cloudy Mountains* may forget the actual place of his dream and join over the centuries the long tradition of those who sang the West Lake in their poems or their paintings. On the contrary, Li Song depicts West Lake with visual accuracy, and the dream it initiates transports the viewer less philosophically than emotionally. Although *Dream Journey* is not a pure topographical landscape, its aim is to provide, like *West Lake*, the feeling of actually traveling to the Xiao Xiang. The warm and humid atmosphere of the riverscape is rendered with great sensitivity through the depiction of villages, the vegetation, and the waters merging with the clouds. Yet the details that testify to the verisimilitude of this view of the Xiao Xiang do not break the overall unity of the landscape.

The Unlimited View

The unified panorama of *Dream Journey* contrasts with those of *West Lake* and *Delight* because its central section recedes toward an unlimited distance. The vision of a vast view that continuously recedes into the infinite often stimulated poets to recall previous journeys and to meditate on the contrast between such temporal experiences and the timelessness of

landscape. Certain motifs, such as a flight of geese, or geese alighting at sunset, which have long been associated with the *Eight Views of the Xiao and Xiang*, especially the section entitled *Pingsha loyan*, "Wild Geese Alight on Level Sand," before it gained independence as a theme, conveyed a powerful impression of mental escape. Su Shi wrote a poem on one of the pictures of wild geese and reeds by the monk Huichong (ca. 965–1017), saying that the painter's image of the Xiao and Xiang rivers awakened in him the desire to travel.⁴⁰ The depiction of the movement of the geese flying served to represent spatial depth. Often the motif was associated with a receding stream, one of the earliest technical solutions used by Chinese landscape painters to convey a sense of space. It is mastered beautifully in *Dream Journey*'s central section where the zigzagging river pouring from the central mountain extends the viewer's gaze into the depth of the painting (Fig. 2). The viewer's examination of the stream is guided by the movement of the geese, as they do, for instance, in *Queen Vaidehi's First Meditation on the Setting Sun* (*ri xiang guan*), in cave 172 in Dunhuang (eighth century) (Fig. 17), an image used in Pure Land Buddhism.⁴¹ The queen sits on a mat in the open air, looking across the level desert sands to the red orb of the sun sinking behind the mountains. Her sight is directed toward the horizon by a flock of wild geese. In much the same way, the flying geese of *Dream Journey* follow the central mountain and provide movement along a diagonal line. The infinite expansion of the gaze is a poetic vision, and is described in Tang poetry. A

⁴⁰ Y. Shimizu and C. Wheelwright, *Japanese Ink Paintings*, Princeton, 1976, 224, n. 30. A later example is given in a poem by Liu Ji (1311–75) on a painting by Muqi entitled "One Thousand Birds Painting." It reads:

In former times Huichong painted reeds and wild geese.
Looking at them was like wandering about on rivers and lakes.
Now there is only this picture, but it is even more admirable.
In it there are a thousand *li* of the Xiao and Xiang rivers in autumn. . . .

The translation in full is given by N. Wey, in "Mu-ch'i and Zen Painting," Ph.D. diss., Chicago University, 1974, 63–64. As K. Suzuki points out, the imagery of this poem suggests a painting similar to "Descending Geese" in the *Eight Views* attributed to Muqi. See "Ryô Kai, Mokkei, Gyokkan" ("Liang Kai, Muqi, Yujian"), *Sô Gen meigashu*, Tokyo, 1970, 30.

⁴¹ The *Amitayur-dhyana Sutra* (*Guanjing bianxiang*), a popular subject in the High Tang, relates that Amithaba once gave Queen Vaidehi sixteen objects to meditate upon as a spiritual consolation for the brutal refusal of her son Ajatasatru to allow her to look after her husband, King Bimbisara, in prison. The first object was the setting sun "to which all things that have sight are meant to turn their eyes." Trans. in *Sacred Books of the East*, Oxford, 1894, XLIX, 161. In a *pipa* panel preserved in the Shoso-in, another 8th-century painting, a group of musicians rides an elephant in the foreground, and a flight of birds leads the eyes into the far distance where the sun sets. Repr. in M. Sullivan, *Chinese Landscape Painting in the Sui and Tang Dynasties*, Berkeley, 1980, figs. 52–53. Another similar case is found on the walls of a Buddhist temple near Chengdu (Sichuan Province), where Zhang Xun is said to have painted a sunset along with dawn and noon, around 881–885. Sullivan, 80.

quatrain by Wang Wei from the same period captures much the same sense of poetic fancy:

Autumn hills capture the late light
Birds fly two by two
Verdant greens appear here and there
Evening mists hide and go.⁴²

The bird's-eye view stimulates the reader's spatial imagination. Wang Wei as well as other High Tang poets opened a mental space that inspired painters who took the illusion of space as one of their main goals and who adopted landscape as a favorite subject matter. The birds of the poem lead the reader's imagination toward the infinitely far, and the image is borrowed by painters who find the flying flock particularly suitable for the enhancement of an impression of the "level distance" (*pingyuan*). Both the Tang paintings and, later, *Dream Journey* use that spatial feature to achieve pictorial depth and thus to depict an image of either meditation or dream.

In Wang Wei's poem, as in *Dream Journey*, the movement of the viewer's eyes toward the background is key to the experience of space. In the poem, the scattered and fleeting images suggest the movement of the geese flying. This movement is not only physical but also psychological, an enhancement of the illusion of movement. The impression of movement stimulated either by the fleeting images of the poem or by the painted landscape that recedes into depth simulates a traveling experience and engages the reader in the contemplation of infinitude.

Su Shi often used the metaphor of a vast view in order to convey the feeling of transience. For example, in "The Temple of Great Qin," he invites the reader to ascend progressively to a pagoda from which he can discover an ever-rolling plain "vast like the ocean":

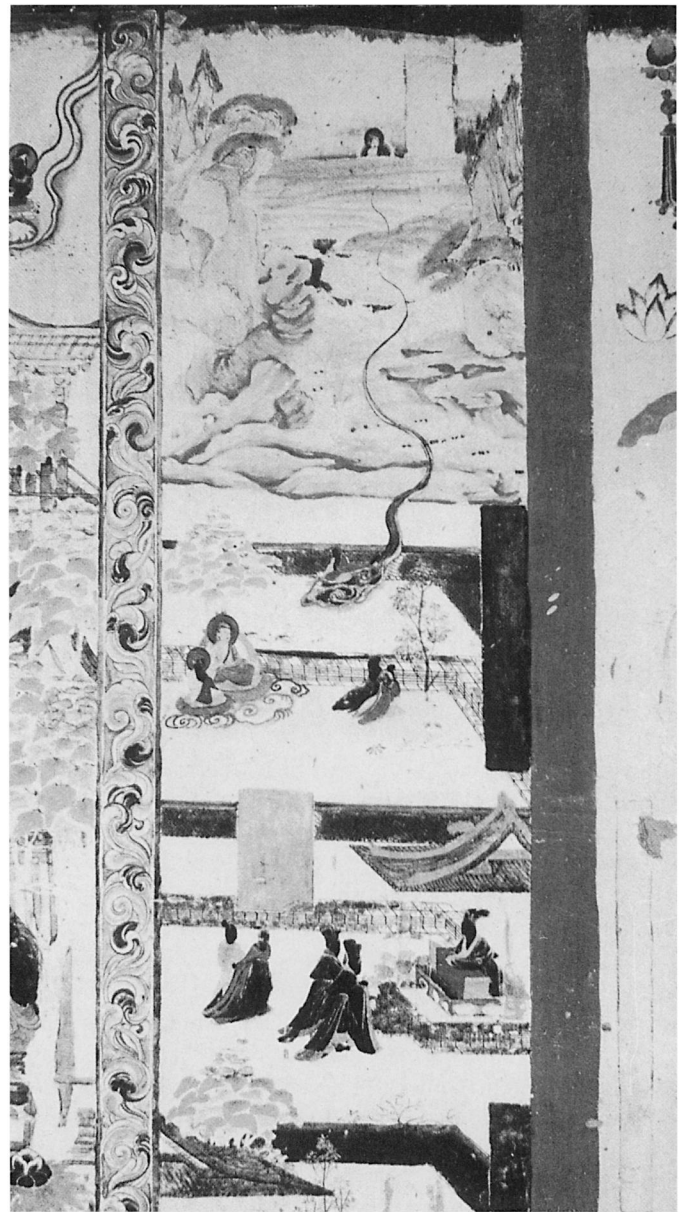
Even is the river plain opening a bright space,
Uneven are the blue foothills stretching out.
Suddenly I see in the distance a lone pagoda:
Isolated and sparkling amid the jumbled mountains.
I pursue my search, proceeding far off.
Standing in the wind, leaning back, startled:
The plain below is vast like the ocean,
Unrolling toward the east.⁴³

The shift of perspective on the flat plain, first seen from below, then from the top of the pagoda, signals a spiritual elevation that the traveler in either the poem or the painting attains through his detachment from the world he has left behind.

Su does not scorn the petty world that is below, however; instead he sees into it. For the late Northern Song scholars, one of the aims of travel was to understand better the structure of the world and to question the present in the light

⁴² *Magnolia Park*, from the Wang Stream series, in Chen Yixin, *Wang Wei shixuan*, Beijing, 1959, 27.

⁴³ T. Ogawa and K. Yamamoto, *So Tōba shishū*, Tokyo: Chikuma, 1983, 1, 529–530.



17 Anonymous, Tang dynasty, 8th century, *Queen Vaidehi's First Meditation on the Setting Sun (Ri xiang guan)*, wall painting. Cave 172, Dunhuang (after *Dunhuang bihua* in *Zhongguo meishu quanji*, pt. 2, xv, 77)

of the past. In 1170 Lu You still traveled for the government but he had grown tired of it. He ended a poem as follows:

Fog lifts from reedy villages, red in the setting sun;
Rain ended, from fishermen's huts the damp smoke of cooking fires.
I turn my head, look toward home, now a thousand mountains away;
A trip up the gorges; we've just passed a rapid one.
When I was young I used to dream of the joys of official travel;
Older now, I know just how hard the going can be.⁴⁴

⁴⁴ "Blue Rapids," in Lu You, II, 2. Trans. B. Watson, *The Old Man Who Does as He Pleases: Selections from the Poetry and Prose of Lu Yu*, New York, 1973, 6.

The poet's trip through a foggy, rainy, smoky landscape is ending. Looking back, he realizes the distance he has covered during his trip and during all the previous ones where his official career took him. The landscape seen from afar prompts him to express his sadness after so many travels, which brought him so little political success. Unlike Su Shi, who searched for knowledge of the workings of the world, Lu You held the Song government's foreign policy responsible for shrinking Chinese land. His numerous travels along the Yangzi River exposed him to the painful evidence that the Song had not recovered the North. He therefore associated travel with the sadness of political reality and with the transience of the world. In 1176 he wrote "Spring Sadness." The first quatrain reads:

Spring sadness, vast and wide, blankets earth and sky.
Before I reach where I'm going, sadness gets there first,
Filling the eyes like clouds suddenly blowing up,
Visiting men like a fever—how can they escape?⁴⁵

Lu You's poem has a second couplet, on drinking, that ends with the realization that "Sadness and wine can do nothing for each other." In his expression of sorrow, Lu You shows less philosophical coolness than Su Shi and more passion. Lu's multisided perception of reality enables him to express his thoughts through sensation, which is characteristic of the active man he was. Sadness becomes so visually concrete that it fills his eyes, getting there before perception of the clouds of the vast sky. His vision of these traveling experiences comes back in his memory as a dream, and the scene he crosses now reveals nature through a haze, as if it were also a dream. Similarly the washed landscape of *Dream Journey* evokes, by its dreamlike silhouettes, a journey along memories of previous trips or a dream of desired ones. The distance established in both poem and painting creates a longing for the other side; it is by bridging such a distance that truth can be attained. The clouds create a distance in space and time that longs to be bridged. But even the poet's memory fails to bring happiness back. All he can do is let his eyes be filled with the clouds, like Yungu, to dream about them, and to let his imagination wander in the limitless space. Yungu, the recipient of the painting, who had traveled throughout many mountains of China, would view the painting as the expression of both his dream to travel to the Xiao Xiang and his understanding that life is transient.

The archetypal theme of hills and water that extend into infinity and force the viewer to sharpen his eyes is central to *Dream Journey*'s complex spatial structure. The viewer is alerted to recognize that things exist only once they are perceived. In the poem as in the painting, the landscape appears unlimited because it is blurred by mists and clouds. In fact, the clouds painted in light ink washes create the sense of distance. Yet pale clouds exist in the mind as a symbol for a longed-for place. They are not unattainable, but simply described from a distance. Lu You's destination is located beyond the clouds—symbolizing sadness—and the central

peak of *Dream Journey* is depicted within the clouds, but those clouds exist only for the viewer looking at them from a distance. Indeed, clouds dissolve as soon as one reaches them, and none can be seen any longer. Thus, the only way to reach the pale clouds is to gaze at them. This image was often used by Wang Wei, who mastered the impression of distance created by clouds when he wrote, "I walk till the stream ends/ And sit to watch the clouds begin."⁴⁶ In the poem as in the painting, the limits of an ideal world are defined by both viewer and clouds. The condition for this world to exist is to be gazed at, and imagined through the obscuring clouds. Painting had to wait for the Southern Song to convey, through ink technique, the spatial extension already enunciated in Wang Wei's poetry. Training his eyes to contemplate blurred vistas that are about to dissolve, the viewer concentrates upon sensuous experiences offered by a landscape, which becomes an analogy for human feelings such as sadness for the fragility and impermanence of life. This experience is that of a poet.

Illusory Space

Since *Dream Journey* presents a remarkably clear spatial articulation, which in fact permits the viewer to see more than he could if he were in front of the real landscape, it seems contradictory that its details are blurred. The effort at clarity achieved by the spatial construction seems undercut by a technique that transforms natural forms into ambiguous shapes. These forms, modified through water, become as difficult to grasp as if they were unreal, and the viewer has to guess what the silhouettes represent (Figs. 5, 6). The poetry that results from this visual effect appears at different levels. First, the vagueness of forms evokes a poetic ambiguity. Preventing the viewer from a clear visual analysis of the scene, the painter, like the poet, uses the metaphor of blurred vision, created, for instance, by mists or by tears, in order to express feelings indirectly.⁴⁷ The effect of blur pervades the atmosphere and relates to the infinity of space and, by implication, to the overflow of emotions and to the specific situation of parting or travel. At a deeper level, the perception of misty forms induces a transformation of these forms in the poet's mind. This phenomenon is discovered by painters at the time of the creation of the poetic themes of the Eight Views. For example, Huihong's poem on one of the Eight Views, entitled "Returning Sail off Distant Shore," reads,

The river's current swallows the sky, a distant traveler's
sailboat;
Leaning on a railing, threads of thoughts tangled in
the wind,
Over a vast expanse, I suspect I see a wild duck or goose.
Gradually aware of a mast emerging through the glare,

⁴⁶ Quoted by Guo Xi in *Lingqian gaozhi*. In *MSCS*, ix, 1: 4.

⁴⁷ Accordingly, poets would link the metaphor of tears blurring a lover's or a friend's vision to the evocation of sorrowful moments. In a poem beginning with "Feelings are like drifting love-threads," Zhou Gizhi (fl. mid-12th century) borrows images from an atmospheric landscape seen through tears in order to convey the sadness of two lovers parting. See text and commentary in Jiang Shangxian, ed., *Tang Song mingjia ci xin xuan*, Tainan, 1963, 298–299.

⁴⁵ In K. Yoshikawa, *An Introduction of Sung Poetry*, trans. B. Watson, Cambridge, Mass. 1967, 151.

This time—adding or detracting—you must rely on the poet's vision.⁴⁸

The goose stirs the poet's vision out of the illusion of a misty landscape. Using expressions such as "I suspect," "gradually aware," "adding or detracting," the poet compels the reader to see a world like a dream. The atmospheric phenomena conspire to fool the poet's perception. Similarly, the haziness of *Dream Journey* affects our mode of perception as much as the objects themselves, and the image seems to be seen in a dream as well.

However representative of the actual Xiao Xiang the painted landscape may appear, its overall effect is that of a dream, or an illusory vision. From the hazy medium of the painted scroll, successive layers of light washes (*danmo*) build forms that emerge like shadows (*wangliang*). The fugitive, shifting images seem to materialize from nowhere, as in a dream.⁴⁹ We see the atmosphere existing between the natural elements and our eyes. Space is given substance; yet it is no longer suggested by solid texturing and cannot be measured. The forms are given presence and unity by an ink-wash technique that in itself invites attention. Yet the technique denies the substantiality of the ghostlike silhouettes and suppresses a clear distinction between things. If we push the viewing experience further, we might ask: are we looking at trees disappearing into mist or at traces of ink on paper? As we see the interaction of paper and brush and ink—how the paper absorbs the diluted washes and how the brush reveals forms made of the thinnest strokes—our perception oscillates between the illusory and material reality. What is hidden by mists seems to vanish like mist, whereas, in fact, it disappears by being hidden.⁵⁰ By depicting the manner by which forms appear through atmosphere, *Dream Journey* forces the viewer to question the reality of those forms and thus produces the illusion of traveling in space and in time. The direct implication of this fragmentation of space is an impression of movement.

In *Dream Journey*, none of the forms are permanently fixed. The brushwork reveals them in the brevity of a moment. We perceive only glimpses of things, such as mountains, trees, temples, and boats, which coalesce and dissolve successively in a perpetual movement within the atmospheric environment. The movement is no longer solely a horizontal progression, parallel to the picture plane, as was the case with the

dramatic rising and falling movement of eleventh-century vistas. Rather, the forms emerge and disappear in depth, within the paper, and it is the shift of the viewer's sight from one object to the next that makes the landscape intelligible. The painter conceived of *Dream Journey* in dynamic terms, as matter in process in the sense of the original, pre-Socratic word for form: *rhuthmos*, rhythm, the impact on forms of the action of viewing. The landscape's motion resides primarily in the brushwork, which forces the viewer to shift his sight constantly in order to combine the various components of each form. *Dream Journey* engages the viewer in far more than a rudimentary act of looking. The act is always repeated, in an attempt to extract the form from a fleeting process. The aesthetic value of the brushwork resides precisely in the exercise it imposes on the viewer's eyes. Two real-time processes—of the painting practice and of the activity of viewing—meet on the picture plane. The viewer apprehends the forms within the experience that has created them, in visual participation in the process of making. This model of dynamism addresses how space is traveled through and how objects become visible. Thus the understanding of space is mandatory for the understanding of theoretical knowledge.⁵¹

Dream Journey thereby challenges the act of viewing. In this sense it is less a description than an exercise done with the spontaneity which Song literati associated with the quality of *pingdan*, or the even and bland. Jiangnan artists studied the "impression" left in their imagination by natural forms seen through the moist atmosphere of southern China, and perception itself became the subject matter of their paintings. This visual experience, called by the colophon writers an "intuitive communion" (*xinhui*) with the depicted landscape, creates a poetic illusion. Zhang Shen explained that, upon looking at *Dream Journey*, "his mind was in communion with the painting," and Ge Fu added later that "his mind was in communion with the real scene." Zhang Guimou, another colophon writer, commented on the scroll: "The whole landscape is an illusion (*huan*). This painting is the illusion of an illusion. Even the present words are illusion and illusion again." Besides the borrowing of Chan Buddhist vocabulary which reveals that the scholars who wrote comments on *Dream Journey* found the painting an appropriate support for mediation on the notion of illusion, the ink-wash images that literally move in and out of focus are a poetic manifestation, for only poetry can help painting establish the relationship between the real world and that of illusion.

In the aesthetic vision of Southern Song literati, nature is given the attributes of a painter, an illusion that can occur in poetry. Calling nature "the Lord of Heaven," Yang Wanli wrote:

The Lord of Heaven wants to fill my poet's eyes,
But he's worried lest the autumn mountains be too
withered, insipid.

⁵¹ How to give a sense of movement has been a major concern since the earliest theorists wrote on painting. The "First Law" of Xie He (active ca. 500–535), *qiyun shengdong*, is a principle of animation; it is essentially a principle of space. This principle recalls Aristotle's concept of "kinesis," which implies that movement and space are not separated from thinking and perceiving. See O. Barfield, *Saving the Appearances: A Study of Idolatry*, London, 1957, 101.

⁴⁸ Trans. Murck (as in n. 8), 225.

⁴⁹ Almost all the Song commentators on the painting admired this dreamlike quality which creates an illusion in the viewers' minds. In order to convey the mysterious way in which the ink washes metamorphose into landscape forms, they use the term *huan*, or *maya*, which conveys both illusion and transformation. For these scholars trained in Chan Buddhism by Yungu, the value of the painting rests both in the visual process through which the viewers complete the forms and on the illusory quality of the hazy images that gradually emerge from the mist. *Dream Journey's* visual exercise, whose main characteristic is a gradual focusing imposed by the fleeting images, is thought to enable the viewer to purify his perception and thereby advance one step toward enlightenment. For Zhang Guimou, this quality is due to the painter's spontaneous ink technique, which could break through the barrier of illusory outer appearances and gain the inner essence of Jiangnan landscape. See Malenfer (as in n. 4), 287–289.

⁵⁰ According to J. Gibson, space is understood as the eyes shift from one recognizable object to the next. *The Senses Considered as Perceptual Systems*, Boston, 1966, 67.

So suddenly he designs the brocade of Shu and spreads
out the crimson of Wu;⁵²
Low, low, he rubs them on autumn mountains halfway
up.
In a second he turns the red brocade into kingfisher
gauze;
His loom weaves out ravens, and kingfisher gauze
disappears,
And all I see is the clear river pure as silk.⁵³

In Yang's poem the disappearance of firm ground through mists happens at three levels. First, the vast territory spanning Shu and Wu is reduced to a single scene. This can happen only in poetry and not in ordinary perception. Similarly, in *Dream Journey*, the Eight Views are conflated into a single panorama, which confirms that *Dream Journey* retains more of the poetic quality than those handscroll paintings where each view is presented separately. If space is transformed into a poetic composition, time too is reconstructed. In Yang's poem, the weaving of Heaven's tapestry happens in an instant, and this handiwork vanishes in another flash. Yang's poetic vision, in which the transformations of the landscape have wiped away the illusory creations of the Lord of Heaven and brought a sudden vision of a "clear river pure as silk," is historically rooted in the tradition of Chinese poetry. In effect, because the last line of the poem is a direct quotation from a famous verse from the Southern Qi poet Xie Tiao (464–499),⁵⁴ historical distance is erased once again. Mistiness contributes to the poetic illusion: the mountains are rubbed in red halfway up and merge with the sunset light. At the end of the poem they are detached from solid ground, as if floating in a dream. Not only are the geographical and historical "connections" erased, but the connection to a complete scene is also eliminated. This disintegration of the empirical world allows for its reintegration as "mood" (*qu*), the poetic condition defined by Mi Fu and the literati.

In Yang's words, nature designs, paints, embroiders, and weaves. The changes in the scenery at sunset are compared to the magical weaving of the finest brocades and the riverscape is likened to a silk painting. The work of art presents to the poet a different world, different kinds of scenes and relations, so that he believes that nature *is* art. Only poetry, by means of juxtaposition of images that would be otherwise difficult to visualize at once, can establish that relationship. It is a question of perception in which nature produces forms like those of a visual poem. In turn the painting can become a substitute for nature, the contemplation of which offers spiritual rewards.

As seen in Yang Wanli's poem, the cult of aesthetics and of the aesthetic dream in late twelfth- and thirteenth-century poetic painting is an attempt to make the world art and art

the world. Perhaps it reveals a desire to close the eyes to the threatening reality of the present. Southern Song paintings such as *Dream Journey* make dreams beautiful and teach pleasure in the act of remembering them. The occasion and act of recollection are given a central place now at the expense of the dream itself. And in this art built on the model of the dream, a doubling occurs: the dream is not only the model of the painting, it is also a favorite topic within the painting. Therefore the act of remembering through a dream while viewing a painting is a topic in itself. Its most immediate benefit is the achievement of mental freedom. Mi Youren wrote an inscription in 1141 on *White Clouds on the Xiao and Xiang* (*Xiao Xiang bayun tu*, Shanghai Museum), which reads in part,

The finest aspect of the mountains' *qi*
Is the contracting and expanding, lightening and
darkening of the clouds.
If one's heart is imprisoned in the capital
One wishes to be the lord riding the waves.⁵⁵

The mountains' *qi* is assimilated to the clouds; the lord riding the waves is a fisherman, symbol of freedom. The visualization of clouds merging with mountains, a metaphor for the contrasting and expanding of nature's *qi*, or vital breath, constitutes an essential part in the investigation of the world and of the creative self. For Yungu, who received *Dream Journey* after thirty years of wandering in nature, the painted scroll of clouds and mountains gives him the means to continue his investigation by participating in the creative process of nature. The result of such an understanding of the world is a detachment from worldly concerns, a liberation of the mind, which is duplicated when one dreams about clouds while looking at a painting. The absorption of the *qi* of clouds by Mi recalls the breathing techniques mastered by Zong Bing in the fifth century. A dreamer can relate this cosmic breathing to the experience of the immensity of the universe, as in one of Goethe's *Sonnets to Orpheus*, which begins with the following: "To breathe, o invisible poem!/
Pure exchange which never ends between our own being and the expanses of the world. . . ." The exchange of being goes as far as creating equality between the dreamer who breathes and the breathed world of the landscape. When the viewer-dreamer has detached himself from worries, when he can finally contemplate a beautiful aspect of the universe without counting time, he feels an opening within him.

Because Southern Song paintings such as *Dream Journey* present a view of the landscape, here the Xiao Xiang, so faithful to the original site, and, at the same time, so appropriate for dreaming about it, the viewers can feel that they have never seen that place well unless they have dreamt what they are seeing in the painting. This reverie is a manifest psychic activity. Differing from the dream that occurs during sleep, reverie, or daydream, benefits from lucid tranquility, which is a requirement for the dream to

⁵² The Shu area of modern Sichuan and the Wu area of Jiangsu were both famous for their textiles, to which Yang is comparing the evening colors.

⁵³ "I Break Out in Song while Spending the Night at East Bank," in Yang Wanli, 26: 250b, trans. adapted from Schmidt (as in n. 29), 119.

⁵⁴ Schmidt (as in n. 29), 164, n. 57.

⁵⁵ This inscription is the second one by Mi following his painting. Included in *Shiqu baoji xubian*, comp. Zhang Zhao *et al.*, fac. rep., National Palace Museum, Taipei, 1971, 1232, trans. adapted from Sturman (as in n. 39), 245.

become deeper.⁵⁶ Hence it allows continuity, that is, the dreamer's being invades the world. He lives by his daydream in a world homogeneous with his being. There is no inside and outside; the space of dream is a plastic mediator, materialized by the painted landscape, between the viewer and the universe. *Dream Journey* allows Yungu to expand his self both in place and in time. Indeed, Chinese landscape painting, because it is not restricted to scientific perspective, does not confine the viewer's self to strict limits. Already when Zong Bing advised painters on how to represent distant views, the aim of painting landscape was to capture the whole universe within a few inches of painted material.⁵⁷ By inviting him to explore limitless dimensions of a landscape, even more boundless than a real scene, it expands his vision beyond the limits of his body. Then the world is immense, great, and the one who dreams it feels enlarged. This grandiose image is that of the poet who becomes intoxicated by drinking at the cup of the world, the cup described by Yang Wanli. Certain poetic images, such as the cup—and the cup-shaped mountain receiving the visit of clouds—offer a privileged means to magnify the world and to create a cosmos.

One of the most significant aesthetic qualities of pictorial dream journeys is that they lift the dream out of the normal category of experience. The blurred quality of the flickering images seem to deny any differentiation of the materiality of things. In addition, a painting, such as *Dream Journey*, offers no clear boundary between illusion and reality; no section shows a waking of the dreamer. This expression of an unresolvable duality between illusion and reality illustrates at one level Zhuangzi's proverbial butterfly dream and the Daoist notion of the "Nondifferentiation of Things" (*qiwu*). At another level, this ambiguity indicates a Buddhist concern with detachment from reality, as expressed in the Song colophons stating that all is illusion, even this painting. One of the writers of the inscriptions, Zhang Guimou, adds that to inscribe the painting, that is, to express a discursive thought about it, is as foolish as to attempt to explain a dream. Their insistence upon the illusion of a form that is difficult to grasp leads to the belief in a dream as the ultimate reality, and in a painted dream as the expression of that reality. Indeed, in

daydream the communication between the dreamer and his world is very intense, since it does not have that distance which marks the perceived world, the world fragmented by perception. Cosmic daydream makes the viewer live in a state that could be called ante-perceptive, because the image is immediate and gives the dreamer the whole before the parts. The unified image of *Dream Journey* gives the viewer a unity of daydream, a unity of world, in which undivided images do not contradict each other. Therefore to see the Xiao Xiang in a daydream is to see with a vision sharper and deeper than that afforded by the eyes only. Such a contemplation is a sign of knowledge, which, according to Song philosophy, can lead to sagehood. For that reason, painters, such as the one of *Dream Journey*, and poets, such as Yang Wanli, have produced an art whose reading helps to cultivate one's artistic perception and poetic knowledge.

Valérie Malenfer Ortiz, a Harvard Ph.D. (1990), is also publishing on the impact of Chan/Zen Buddhism on Song ink painting—its technique and its function as a mode of communication among scholars [New York University, Washington Square East, New York, N.Y. 10003].

Frequently Cited Sources

Chen Gaohua, *Song hao jin huajia shiliao* (*Historical Index of Song, Liao, and Jin Painters*), Beijing: Wenwu chubanshe, 1984.

HSCS=*Huashu congshu* (*Collected Works on the History of Painting*), ed. Yu Anlan (Shanghai: Renmin meishu, 1963), repr., Taipei: Wenshi zhe chubanshe, 1974.

Lu You (1125–1209), *Jiannan shigao* (*Collected Poems from Jiannan*), in *Lu Fangwen quanp*, Beijing: Beijing shi Zhongguo shudian, 1986.

MSCS=*Meishu congshu* (*Collected Works on Fine Arts*), ed. Deng Shi and Huang Binhong (Shanghai: Shenzhou guoguang she, 1911–36), repr. Taipei: Yiwen, 1975.

SBCK=*Sibu congkan* (*Collected Reprints of the Four Bureaux*), comp. Zhang Yuanji et al., Shanghai: Hanfenlu, 1919–36.

Words and Images: Chinese Poetry, Calligraphy, and Painting, ed. A. Murck and W. Fong, Princeton, 1991.

Yang Wanli, *Chengzhai ji* (*The Collected Works of Sincere Studio*), included in SBCK, XIV.

ZGHLB=*Zhongguo hualun leibian* (*Chinese Painting Theory by Category*), ed. Yü Jianhua (Beijing: Zhongguo gudian yishu, 1957).

⁵⁶ For the differentiation between *rêve* and *rêverie*, see G. Bachelard, *The Poetics of Reverie*, New York, 1969, 63.

⁵⁷ In *Hua shanshui xu*, included in *Li dai ming hua j*, fol. 4, and quoted in ZGHLB, 583–584.